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PRESENT

BHARAT AI STARTUPS

REPORT 2026

FOREWORD

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India stands at a pivotal moment in its Artificial Intelligence (AI) journey. After years of research, experimentation and early adoption, we are entering a phase where AI is becoming foundational to how systems function, services are delivered and value is generated. This shift, from development to deployment, integration and scale, signals India's transition towards building resilient, population-scale AI capabilities.

Beyond technological momentum, it is the depth and diversity of participation from India's innovation ecosystem that gives this moment its distinctive character. India's AI story is being driven by a new generation of entrepreneurs, researchers and startups who are embedding intelligence into real-world workflows across critical sectors such as healthcare, agriculture, education, climate resilience, governance, manufacturing and financial inclusion among various other sectors and domains. These innovators are the backbone of India's AI revolution. By building solutions in complex, diverse and multilingual environments, they are creating systems that are resilient, inclusive and globally relevant by design.

The IndiaAI Mission has been instituted to support and amplify this entrepreneurial momentum by addressing structural constraints that often prevent promising ideas from scaling. By strengthening access to compute, data, capital and talent, the Mission enables founders and researchers to focus on what matters, solving real problems at scale. The rapid expansion of shared and subsidised national AI compute capacity, delivered through the IndiaAI Compute Portal, reflects this commitment: innovation must be enabled through accessible, affordable and shared infrastructure.

Data is a critical enabler of this ecosystem. Through AIKosh, India is building a trusted platform for datasets, models and applications that reflect Indian realities, spanning languages, geographies, demographics and use cases. For startups and entrepreneurs, this significantly reduces friction, shortens development cycles and supports experimentation grounded in representative data. Further, it fosters collaboration by allowing innovation to be built upon common public foundations.

India's startup ecosystem is already demonstrating the strength of this approach. Thousands of young enterprises are AI-native from inception, integrating intelligence into solutions and products from the outset. Many are working closely with government, academia and industry to deploy solutions in live environments, testing, learning and iterating at speed. This ability to move rapidly from concept to deployment is emerging as India's defining advantage in the global AI landscape. I commend Google and Inc42 on the Bharat AI Startups Report 2026 that highlights the scale of opportunity our country presents and the role AI startups can play in advancing the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047.

As this ecosystem grows, trust and responsibility take centre stage. For AI to succeed in a society as diverse as India, solutions must be reliable, explainable and aligned with democratic values. India's AI Governance Guidelines are designed to strengthen innovation by embedding safety, accountability and inclusion from the outset. Startups that adopt the trust-by-design approach will succeed domestically and set global benchmarks.

The years ahead present a rare window of opportunity. Entrepreneurs who build now, owning end-to-end workflows, learning from real-world deployment and creating scalable feedback loops, will emerge as frontrunners. The IndiaAI Mission and the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology will continue to act as force multipliers for this ambition by enabling access, aligning incentives and fostering partnerships that allow innovation to flourish. This report reflects that collective effort. It showcases what Indian innovators have already achieved and extends an invitation for them to do more. To our entrepreneurs and startups: India's complexity is your strength. Solutions that work here can work anywhere. The future of AI in India, and increasingly the world, will be shaped by those who transform ideas into impact.

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

A $126 BN MARKET CREATES CATEGORY-FORMING MOMENTUM

- India has moved into a category-forming AI cycle: from pilots and "AI features" to production deployment and workflow-native systems. The prize is now large enough to be structural: **$126 Bn AI market by 2030** with potential **$1.7 Tn GDP impact by 2035**
- India's AI market is projected to expand **~5.3x in five years**, making this a time-bound build window, not a slow-burn trend
- Even small share outcomes are now meaningful: capturing **less than 1%** of the 2030 market maps to a **~$50–$100 Mn** outcome within a single demand cycle

RESEARCH MOATS ARE THIN, EXECUTION MOATS ARE FORMING

- India's advantage is shifting from "cheap talent" to speed-to-deployment. The gaps in frontier depth remain wide **(140–150+ AI patents vs 35K+ in China; fewer than 10 notable ML models),**
- The immediate **moat is execution:** shipping workflow-native systems that convert pilots into outcomes

ENTERPRISE AI LEADS THE VALUE POOL, CONSUMER AI DRIVES SCALE AND REACH

- **Enterprise AI** becomes the bigger value pool as companies move from experiments to recurring budgets and workflow-wide rollouts **($11 Bn in 2025 → $71 Bn by 2030)**
- **Consumer AI** grows on adoption and distribution **($13 Bn → $55 Bn)**, with monetisation shifting towards recurring revenue, with **app subscriptions & IAP** emerging as the fastest-growing engine

ADOPTION IS MASSIVE, HABIT WILL UNLOCK REVENUE

- India is already an adoption superpower: the next game is monetisation depth. India is the world's **#2 market for AI app downloads (177 Mn in 2024)**, but monetisation remains early **(~$12 Mn in consumer in-app spend)**
- That translates to **~$0.07 of consumer in-app spend per download**, a wide usage-to-revenue gap that will be closed first by products building habit

INDIA IS A GLOBAL-GRADE STRESS TEST

- India's scale is not just market size, it is a reliability filter. With **886 Mn+ internet users and 22 official languages**, deployment failures surface faster and at a higher cost, making trust-by-design a production requirement
- Products that survive Bharat-scale complexity become more robust for global deployment

SOVEREIGN DISCOUNT IS LOWERING THE COST OF EXPERIMENTATION

- **Innovation Tax is falling.** As compute and ecosystem capacity widen, defensibility shifts to what compounds in production — embedded workflows, repeatable outcomes, and proprietary data loops
- Public rails such as the **IndiaAI Mission** and subsidised access to **~38,000 GPUs** (~₹65 per hour) is lowering the innovation tax and compressing prototype-to-production timelines

APPLICATION FUNDING DOMINATES, IndiaAI AND GOOGLE COMPUTE REDUCE DEPENDENCY

- **Capital is flowing towards execution overinfrastructure.** Indian AI startups have raised **$1.8 Bn+ since 2020; ~86%** has gone to the application layer, and **~69%** of funded startups are seed stage, signalling an ecosystem optimised for shipping
- **This application-heavy skew increases infrastructure dependency.** IndiaAI's public compute stack, built with ecosystem players including Google, reduces dependency by widening national compute capacity and hardware options (including **1,050 Trillium TPUs** under the public compute programme)
- The strategic gap remains stack depth. Relatively small pools into infrastructure and foundation layers **($106 Mn infrastructure; $130 Mn foundation models)** increase dependency if global stacks tighten, while creating clear white space for sovereign infrastructure and domain-specific models

MOATS & THE DEFINING YEARS FOR ACHIEVING ESCAPE VELOCITY

- **Trust has become the gating factor for scale.** As tools commoditise, differentiation shifts to deployment confidence: governance, reliability, and auditability, especially in regulated and mass-market contexts
- **2026–2030 will define India's AI incumbents** as categories harden, enterprise deployments deepen and monetisation stabilises
- The two years are the **highest-leverage founding window,** before consolidation raises the cost of user acquisition and market expansion

01

INDIA’S AI MOMENT IS HERE

India's AI Market Is Entering Its Defining Phase

A Rare AI Inflection Point : Demand maturity, policy clarity, capital flows, and deployment readiness are converging, creating A Rare AI Inflection Point: Demand

$126 BN
AI MARKET BY 2030

$1.7 TN
GDP IMPACT BY 2035

KEY FIGURES

~$17K vs ~$130K TALENT COST ADVANTAGE

140–150 AI PATENTS FILED (2022)

190+ DATA CENTRES

THE SHIFT

FROM:
Proofs of Concept, "Features"

TO:
Production-Grade Deployment, Workflow-Native Systems

DIFFERENTIATION SHIFTS TO: EXECUTION DEPTH, RELIABILITY, INTEGRATION, COMPOUNDING USAGE

FOUR FORCES ARE ALIGNING

- DEMAND MATURITY: Budgets shifting from pilots to production outcomes
- CAPITAL CONVICTION: Funding rotating towards execution and workflow depth
- POLICY RAILS: Sovereign infrastructure & clearer governance for adoption
- DEPLOYMENT READINESS: Enterprises and platforms pushing build-to-production faster

INDIA IS MOVING FROM AI ADOPTION AT SCALE TO AI ADVANTAGE AT SCALE. THE 2026–2030 CYCLE WILL DEFINE CATEGORY LEADERS. India is transitioning from large-scale AI adoption to large-scale AI advantage. The 2026–2030 period will determine category leaders, as global and domestic players ramp up local capabilities.

India's AI Market Is Entering Its Defining Phase

India is at a rare AI inflection point. Demand maturity, policy clarity, capital flows, and deployment readiness are converging in the same cycle, creating a time-bound build window where AI adoption can translate into durable category creation. The prize is already visible: a projected $126 Bn AI market by 2030 and a potential $1.7 Tn GDP impact by 2035.

AI in India is moving from "proofs of concept" to production-grade deployment, and from "features" to workflow-native systems. As models and tooling become easier to access, the differentiation shifts towards execution depth, who can ship reliably, integrate into real operations, and compound usage into defensibility.

India's Momentum Accelerators

India's AI trajectory is being accelerated by a powerful convergence of talent efficiency, infrastructure maturity, and strategic data sovereignty. While the nation's AI talent remains structurally cost-efficient (~$17K vs ~$130K in the US), the ecosystem is rapidly pivoting from service delivery to IP creation, as evidenced by a steady rise in patent filings.

This growth is anchored by a massive expansion in physical infrastructure; with data center capacity projected to surge fivefold, from 1.7 GW to 8 GW by 2030. This physical foundation is further catalysed by a "data-first" strategy: initiatives like AIKosh are building a democratised data commons, providing the high-quality, localised "fuel" necessary to train models that are culturally and linguistically attuned to the Indian context.

At the same time, global and domestic players are building local capability, not only through hubs, but through long-term bets on applied engineering and deployment. Incumbents and challengers are both building across the stack, signalling that India's AI market is moving from promise to presence.

> *India is moving from AI adoption at scale to AI advantage at scale, with the 2026–2030 cycle set to define category leaders*

Four Forces Are Aligning

Demand Maturity: Budgets shifting from pilots to production outcomes

Policy Rails: Sovereign infrastructure & clearer governance for adoption

Capital Conviction: Funding rotating towards execution and workflow depth

Deployment Readiness: Enterprises and platforms pushing build-to-production faster

Demand Is Pulling The Market Forward

India's AI market expansion is being driven by two demand engines:

Enterprise AI is expected to grow from **$11 Bn (2025) to $71 Bn (2030)** as adoption shifts towards workflow-native deployments across BFSI, manufacturing, healthcare, education, and agriculture

Consumer AI is projected to expand from **$13 Bn to $55 Bn**, supported by India's adoption scale, including **177 Mn AI app downloads,** making India the world's **#2 market** by downloads, with monetisation increasingly shaped by subscriptions and in-app purchases

The usage-to-revenue gap is stark. India needs about **14.75 downloads to earn $1** (177 Mn downloads $12 Mn). It is a clear signal that high engagement does not automatically translate into enterprise value. The real question is which startups close this gap first, and the **advantage will sit with those moving beyond thin wrappers** to build habit-forming utility, not novelty

What's Powering India's AI Scale

India's scale-up is being enabled by a three-part engine: **compute, policy rails, and capital.** Public programmes such as the IndiaAI Mission (₹10,300 Cr) and subsidised access to **~38,000 GPUs (~₹65/hour)** are lowering the innovation tax for startups. Capital is also tilting towards execution, with **$1.8 Bn invested in 2025** (~6.7x vs 2020), alongside platform-led programmes that compress prototype-to-production timelines.

Bharat Scale Is A Global AI Stress Test

India's advantage is building AI that performs at **"Bharat-scale", a high-variance environment of 886 Mn internet users and 22 official languages.** That extreme diversity **makes India the world's most demanding testing ground** AI that can navigate India's linguistic nuance and real-world edge cases will be more robust for global deployment. In this context, **Trust-by-Design is not optional** but foundational. Through the IndiaAI Mission, including AIKosh and its core pillars across compute, skills and responsible AI, India is building compliant, scalable systems designed to operate at national scale and compete globally.

Source: Inc42 Analysis, NITI Aayog, NASSCOMM, Sensor Tower

2026–2030: The Years That Decide The Outcome

2026–2030 will decide whether India turns momentum into durable leadership. As enterprise deployments deepen and monetisation stabilises, advantage will shift to companies that own workflows and earn trust at scale.

Key Signals Of This Cycle

Market: $126 Bn by 2030 | $1.7 Tn GDP impact by 2035

Enterprise AI: $11 Bn (2025) → $71 Bn (2030)

Consumer AI: $13 Bn (2025) → $55 Bn (2030) | 177 Mn AI app downloads (#2 globally)

Catalysts: IndiaAI ₹10,300 Cr | ~38,000 GPUs subsidised | BHASHINI: 22 languages

Capital: $1.8 Bn invested in 2025 (~6.7x vs 2020)

Four Forces Are Converging To Create India's AI Breakout Phase

India's AI convergence is the inflection point: compute, policy, and capital tailwinds create a time-bound window for founders to launch 2026–27 and scale through the next demand cycle.

Growth Driver

Demand Maturity

- 87% of Indian enterprises are actively experimenting with AI
- 47% are moving multiple pilots into production (not just testing)
- India is the 2nd largest market globally for AI app downloads (177 Mn in 2024)
- One-third of startup founders list AI as a primary growth engine
- Enterprise AI is projected to grow to $71 Bn (2030) as spend shifts from "feature pilots" to workflow deployments
- Consumer AI is projected to grow from $13 Bn (2025) to $55 Bn (2030) as pricing, bundling, and distribution mature

Catalysts

Policy Clarity

- ₹10,300+ Cr IndiaAI Mission deploying 38,000 GPUs by 2026–27
- GPU access subsidised at ₹65/hour (60–80% cheaper than commercial)
- BharatGen AI: India's first government-backed multimodal LLM supporting 22 languages
- MeitY 2025 Guidelines: Risk-based, lightweight framework enabling experimentation without heavy-handed restrictions
- ₹1 lakh Cr Research, Development & Innovation (RDI) fund launched to catalyse frontier tech innovation

Capital Flows

- $1.8 Bn+ invested in native AI startups in 2025 (6.7× higher than 2020)
- Investor appetite is shifting towards deep, vertical AI plays (BFSI, healthcare, legal) with clearer ROI, rather than generic wrappers
- AI is projected to add $1.7 Tn to India's GDP by 2035

Deployment Readiness

- Google's build with India approach is helping startups move faster from prototype to production
- Through IndiaAI-aligned collaborations with technology partners, founders get more predictable access to modern AI infrastructure
- Mature partner ecosystems (cloud, data, security and workflow stacks) are making it easier to ship compliant, production-ready deployments

$1.7 Tn AI's Value Addition To Indian GDP By 2035

Source: Inc42 Analysis, NITI Aayog, NASSCOMM, Sensor Tower, PIB, Stanford AI Index 2024, EY CII Report

India's Right To Win At The Global AI Stage

Cost-Advantage Through Talent Efficiency

India's **average AI engineer salary stands at $17K, about 87% lower than the US average of $130K,** enabling a scalable engineering hub for global AI firms. This gap stems from India's established IT services ecosystem and a top-three global ranking in AI talent concentration, with skill penetration leading globally, as per Stanford's AI Index. Multinationals and startups thus optimise R&D costs through India's efficient talent pool.

Software & IT Services Growth Engine

Enterprise AI software and services, projected to grow at a **64% CAGR from 2025 to 2030,** expanding from $2 Bn to $24 Bn, represent one of the fastest-growing and most scalable segment of the global AI value chain. India's proven strengths in engineering at scale, productisation, and service delivery align directly with this opportunity, enabling it to capitalise on a ~12x growth multiplier, one of the largest across all AI sub-segments. By leveraging its IT services backbone, agile startup ecosystem, and global delivery capabilities, India is uniquely positioned to capture a disproportionate share of the $981 Bn global AI market by 2030.

Unit Economics Advantage

Indian startups don't just build cheaper, they can iterate more per dollar and reach profitability sooner as build friction falls. Combined with public compute rails such as IndiaAI (₹10,300 Cr; ~38,000 GPUs subsidised at ~$0.65/hour) and platform-led programmes that compress prototype-to-production, this is shaping a highly capital-efficient AI build environment.

Vernacular-First Moat For Tier II & III Markets

India boasts **886 Mn internet users,** with 692 Mn on social media and growing OTT viewership, with 57% preferring Indic languages, turning linguistic diversity into a competitive edge. Sarvam AI supports 22 languages with over 10 Mn conversation turns via its Samvaad platform, CoRover AI CoRoverai delivers 99% accuracy across 100+ languages. These capabilities enable go-to-market strategies for the next billion users beyond English-centric markets.

Consumer AI Monetisation Momentum

India ranked second globally with **177 Mn AI app downloads in 2024,** yet in-app purchase revenue lagged at at $12 Mn. IAP growth hit 198% (YoY), far exceeding China's 24%, alongside a 64% software spending CAGR and massive distribution via 692 Mn social users and dozens of OTT platforms. This trajectory supports scaling digital adoption into sustainable revenue.

Regulatory Framework As Innovation Enabler

India's AI regulation taking a **balanced "Goldilocks" path,** less restrictive than EU and China, more structured than the US, fostering innovation through the 2023 Digital Personal Data Protection Act (DPDP) and NITI Aayog's responsible AI guidelines. Public sector ethical guardrails further ensure clarity without stifling growth. This environment supports India's AI ecosystem amid diverging global policy approaches.

2026–2027 Is India's Highest-Leverage Window For AI Startups

Founders who build in 2026–2027 can lock in category leadership by 2030. Delaying entry means competing for attention, distribution, and enterprise budgets that incumbents will already influence. From 2028 onward, channels will saturate and categories will consolidate, pushing later entrants into costlier sales motions, bespoke integrations and crowded paid channels. This can push customer acquisition costs 3–4× higher and compress breakout odds to 3–5%.

Founding In 2026–2027

PMF: 2026–2028 → highest willingness to experiment and fastest iteration cycles

Enterprise Wins: 2027–2028 → pilots convert into production spend

Scale Inflection: 2029–2030 → aligned with the next enterprise spend

Breakout Outcomes: 2032–2035 → typical 7–10 year compounding path

Founding In 2028+

The Consolidation Trap: Categories are mature, incumbents are entrenched, and you compete against 5–10 already-funded peers with distribution and buyer mindshare

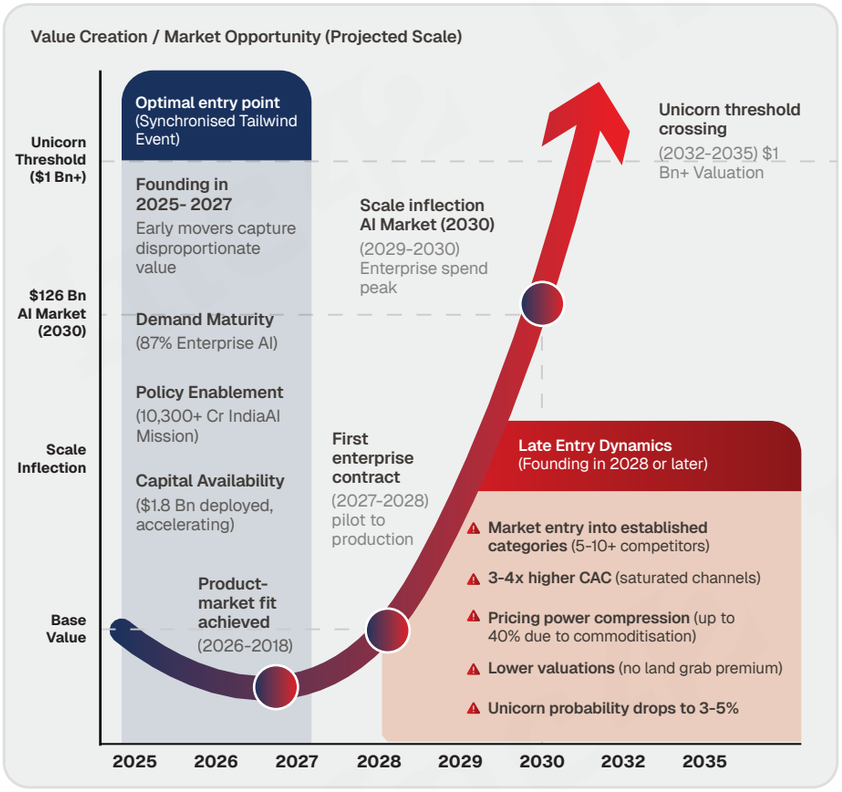
Go-To-Market: CAC rises as channels saturate and buyer attention fragments across competing claims

Pricing Power: Downward pressure as baseline capabilities commoditise and switching costs decline

Fundraising: The "land-grab" premium fade and valuations reset towards execution proof and near-term unit economics

Breakout Odds: Lower, as consolidation raises the cost of catching up and narrows white space to second-order niches

India's AI J-Curve: The Compounding Window (2025–2035)



As India moves towards a projected $126 Bn AI market by 2030, the "land-grab" premium is closing fast. The winners will be those who use India's scale, multilingual complexity and real enterprise workflows to build defensible products and data flywheels before baseline capabilities commoditise and pricing power tightens.

02

INDIA’S AI MOMENTUM ACCELERATORS

India Is Emerging As A Significant Force In The Global AI Economy

India has the cost advantage and the enabling rails across talent, infrastructure and regulation that make scaled AI deployment feasible. The next step is converting these inputs into global-grade products that can compete beyond India.

	INDIA	CHINA	USA	EU & UK
Total AI Patents Granted (2022)	140-150+	35K+	12K+	36K+
Median Pay Levels For AI Engineers	$17K+	$62K+	$130K+	$79K+
Total Data Centres	190+	449+	54K+	23K+
Notable ML Models (2023)	<10	15+	61+	17+
AI Regulations Sentiment	Moderately Restrictive	Highly Restrictive	Moderately Restrictive	Highly Restrictive
Focus On Sovereign AI Development	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

INNOVATION RUNWAY

150 Vs 35K Patents

The white space is large, accelerating patent output and applied IP is a clear compounding lever

TALENT ARBITRAGE

$17K Vs $130K

India's cost efficiency supports faster iteration and broader experimentation. The unlock is retention and depth in frontier roles

INFRASTRUCTURE RUNWAY

190 Vs 54K Data Centres

A large buildout opportunity, especially for AI-ready compute, cloud regions, and inference capacity closer to users

POLICY POSTURE

Balanced, Pro-Innovation

More flexible than highly restrictive regimes. The opportunity is clearer playbooks for safety, data, and accountability without slowing deployment

India's AI Stack Advantage

India can capture higher-margin software layers through talent efficiency, vernacular scale and clearer policy rails, reducing dependence on commoditised hardware.

	What It Enables	Global Leaders	India's Edge
Hardware	Fundamental computing power through specialised processors	NVIDIA, intel, AMD, groq, tenstorrent	NVIDIA/AMD India hubs fuelling local compute access
Foundation Models	Core models and algorithms that power most AI applications	OpenAI, ANTHROPIC, Hugging Face, Meta, Gemini, xAI	Sarvam AI, Ola Krutrim, BharatGen, Airavata focussed on Indian languages and local use
Cloud Infrastructure	Cloud resources to train & deploy models at scale	aws, Azure, Google Cloud	Data center capacity projected to surge 5X, from 1.7 GW to 8 GW by 2030; Reliance JioCloud expansion
Development Platforms	Tools, networks and platforms enabling efficient build, test and deployment	Hugging Face, LangChain, LlamaIndex, crewai	CoRover AI – 99% accuracy across 100+ languages
End User Applications	User-facing apps & solutions solving specific business/consumer needs	perplexity, glean, DUST	Yellow.ai, Gupshup, skit.ai, LimeChat, OnFinance

India Is Building The Next AI Stack Challengers

India's AI stack is being built across two fronts — large incumbents scaling infrastructure and delivery, and AI-native startups pushing new products and capability. Together, they signal a shift from AI adoption to AI execution at scale.

INCUMBENTS
ESTABLISHED PLAYERS

aws
CtrlS
CYIENT
Google Cloud
HCLTech
Infosys
L&T Infotech
Azure
Mphasis The Next Applied
ORACLE Cloud Infrastructure
Reliance Industries Limited
TCS TATA CONSULTANCY SERVICES
Tech Mahindra
wipro

CHALLENGERS
INDIAN NEW AGE STARTUPS

E2E Cloud
fractal
GPU.NET
gupshup
haptik A Jio Company
ModelsLab
NeuroPixel.AI AMPLIFYING DIGITAL STOREFRONTS
OBSERVE·AI
KRUTRIM
OnFinance AI
PIXIS
RagaAI
sarvam
SIGTUPLE
TWO

Source: Inc42
Note: This is an indicative, non-exhaustive list

Startups Tapping India's AI Opportunity

THE STACK

HARDWARE LAYER

CalligoTech, Incore, Morphing Machines, Netrasemi, KRUTRIM, Sensesemi

FOUNDATION MODEL / LLM

avataar, BharatGen, CoRover.ai, gnani.ai, KRUTRIM, sarvam, TWO

AI INFRASTRUCTURE & DEVELOPMENT

auraml, GPU.NET, ModelsLab, KRUTRIM, neysa, ZIROH Labs, truefoundry, Jarvislabs, Anthriq, RagaAI

APPLICATION LAYER

eightfold.ai, MathCo, OBSERVE.AI, PIXIS, qure.ai, JIFFY.ai, VIDEOVERSE, invideo, Neuron7.ai, Leena AI, atomicwork, NURIX

HORIZONTAL VS VERTICAL

HORIZONTAL SOLUTIONS (SECTOR AGNOSTIC)

- **AUDIO/ SPEECH:** beatoven.ai, CoRover.ai, dubpro.ai, Dubverse, MURF.AI, OBSERVE.AI, VODEX
- **VIDEO:** affogato, Clueso, DASHVERSE, FRAMMER AI, invideo, unscript, VisualDub, quso.ai
- **CODE & DATA:** auraml, HEXO, Kombai, KARYA, LLUMO AI, PIXIS, portkey, RagaAI, vue.ai
- **IMAGE & 3D MODELLING:** affogato, Blend, ORBO, Phot.AI, spyne, XenReality
- **TEXT & CONVERSATIONAL AI:** CONVIN, CoRover.ai, gupshup, LimeChat, LONGSHOT, Rootle, skit.ai, VODEX, yellow.ai

VERTICAL SOLUTIONS (SECTOR SPECIFIC)

- **FINTECH/FINANCIAL SERVICES:** artha, Arya.ai, beacon.li, cognext, Hyperbots, MyFi, OnFinance AI, Prudent AI, Rezolv
- **ECOMMERCE/ RETAIL:** FLIX STOCK, MetaModels, NeuroPixel.AI, NITRO COMMERCE, ORBO, spyne, Unstudio AI
- **HEALTHCARE:** boltzmann, cureskin, immunitoAI, innovaccer, qure.ai, RedBrick AI, SIGTUPLE, Suki
- **EDUCATION:** bhanzu, MethdAI, MIKO, SuperKalam, Teachmint, toddle, WAYGROUND, ZuAi
- **ROBOTICS:** CONTROL ONE, CYNLR, GreyOrange, OTTONOMY.IO™, Perceptyne.

Source: Inc42

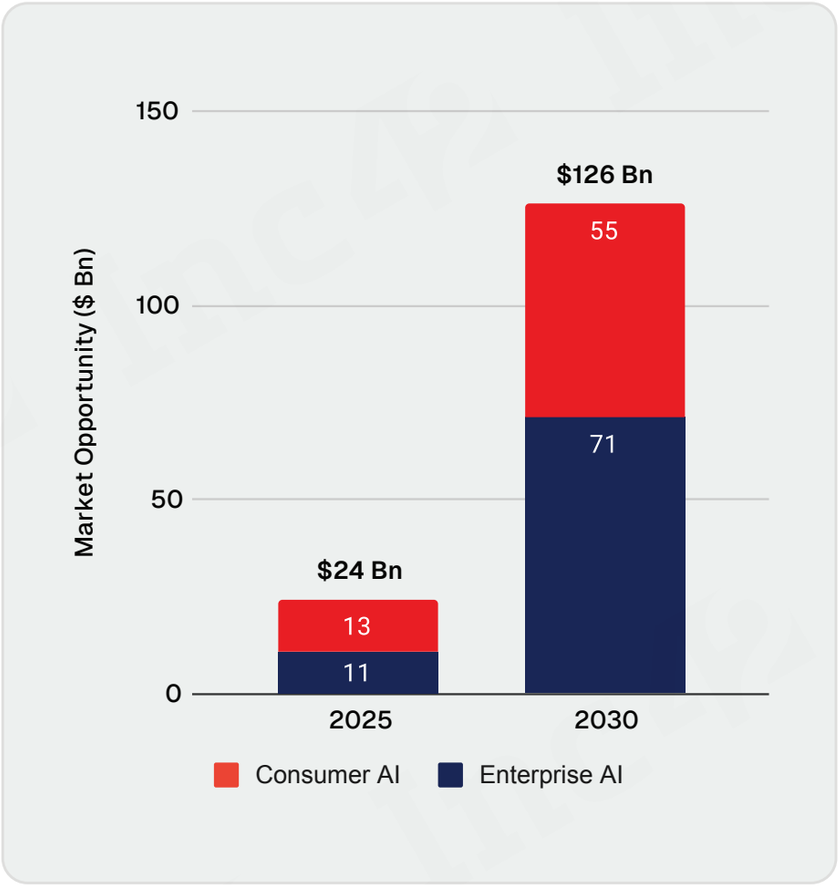
Note: This is an indicative, non-exhaustive list. Some startups may be incorporated outside India, but are founded by entrepreneurs of Indian origin and operate largely from India

03

THE $126 BN OPPORTUNITY

The Dual Growth Engines Of India's $126 Bn AI Market

India's linguistic and cultural diversity creates the world's most dynamic sandbox for AI, enabling products to be tested, localised and fine-tuned at scale.



ENTERPRISE AI ($71 Bn by 2030)

Paying Market Today: Budgets are active and use cases are moving into production

ROI Is Provable: Cost savings and productivity gains show up early

India Advantage: Built on 30 years of software and services execution

CONSUMER AI ($55 Bn by 2030)

Mass Adoption, Early Revenues: 177 Mn downloads, but only ~$12 Mn in app spend so far

The Big Opportunity: Users are trying AI, but paid conversion remains early

Monetisation Window: Stronger revenue models are likely to emerge in 2027–2030

The Scale Effect: India's AI market is projected to expand ~5.3x in five years, reaching $126 Bn by 2030. This is a build-window: teams that invest early in reliable compute access, strong data pipelines, and production-ready deployment will be best placed to capture the next demand cycle.

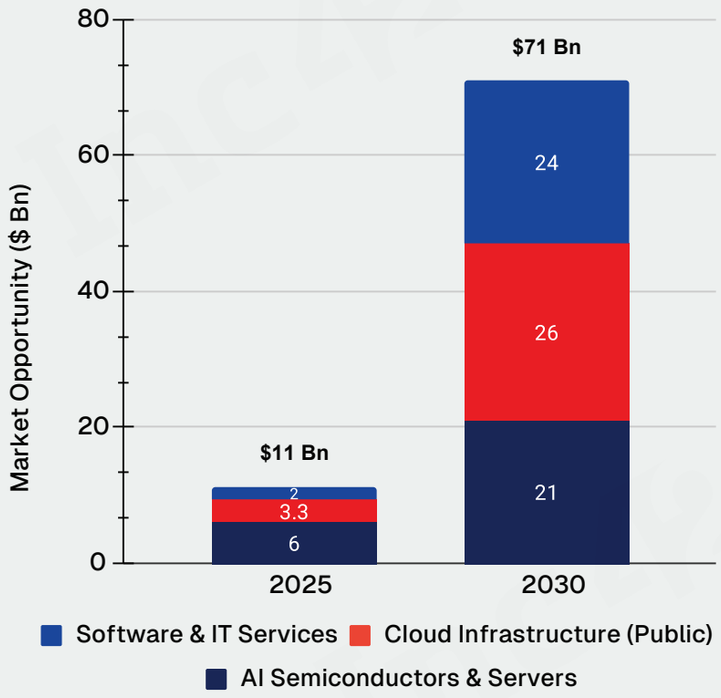
From Consumer-Led To Enterprise-Dominant: Consumer AI drives today's market with a 54% share, but by 2030 Enterprise AI becomes the larger engine at 56% ($71 Bn). The shift is from "cool features" to "embedded outcomes", AI that sits inside workflows, delivers measurable ROI, and meets enterprise expectations on security, compliance, and uptime. The winners will move from horizontal tools to industry-specific, workflow-led products

The TAM Advantage: India's AI TAM is projected to reach $126 Bn by 2030 ($71 Bn enterprise, $55 Bn consumer), making a $50–100 Mn outcome within five years a realistic target for focussed teams. Capturing just 0.07% of the enterprise market or 0.09% of the consumer market can get a seed stage startup there. The takeaway is simple: in this cycle, sub 1% share wins are already venture-scale.

Source: Inc42 Analysis

India's Software Roots Power $71 Bn Enterprise AI Market Opportunity

India's IT services heritage makes it the ideal hub for Software-as-a-Service: building agents that handle complex enterprise tasks with human-like reliability, compliance, and localisation, perfectly matching 87% pilot demand for secure, regulated solutions.



What's Changing In 2025–26

The Great Migration: Chatbots → Agents

AI is moving from "chatting" (GenAI output) to "doing" (agentic execution)

India has long serviced the world's back office, making it a natural home for Software-as-a-Service agents that run workflows end to end

What The Mix Shows (2030)

The biggest value sits in Software & IT Services, where India has a natural edge

Cloud infrastructure accelerates experimentation and deployment at scale

AI servers & semiconductors grow steadily as workloads become predictable and large

Segment	Expected Share	Why It Matters	India's Natural Advantage
Software & IT Services	Dominant (largest pool)	Highest margins come from AI productisation, customisation & deployment at scale	Decades of engineering delivery position India to capture this value pool, supported by top-three global AI talent concentration in enterprise roles
Cloud Infrastructure	Accelerating growth	Enables rapid experimentation, model training, and scalable deployment across enterprises	Decadal capacity expansion and hyperscaler build-outs (including Reliance Jio's expansion) are strengthening India's cloud-ready infrastructure base for enterprise AI deployment.
AI Servers/ Semiconductors	Steady, predictable expansion	Powers compute-intensive workloads as enterprise use cases mature and consolidate	Local NVIDIA/AMD hubs ensure supply chain resilience amid global shortages

Source: Inc42 Analysis

Note: The market opportunity presented reflects only enterprise spending on AI solutions and excludes consumer AI spending

Deployment At Scale Is Emerging As India's Enterprise AI Edge

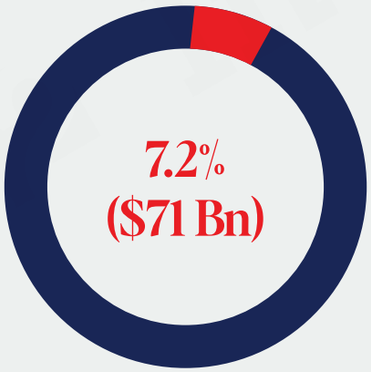
India's enterprise AI advantage is speed to deployment. Gaps in patents and infrastructure still create white space to build defensible, data-resident workflows, while capital and buyer priorities are already rewarding execution-led outcomes.

India's Share Of Global Enterprise AI Market

2025

$644 Bn Global Enterprise AI Expenditure

2030



$981 Bn Global Enterprise AI Expenditure

Source: Inc42 Analysis, EY, Stanford AI Index Report

Where India Can Lead Next

IP Runway: India's AI patents (2022) at 140–150+ remain behind China (35K+) and the US (12K+). This creates a clear white space for founders to build defensible IP inside real-world applications

Model Momentum: With fewer than 10 notable ML models in 2023, India is still early in frontier model-building. This creates room for sovereign and domain-specific models (Indic languages, regulated industries, public-scale use cases)

Infrastructure Catch-Up: India's 190+ data centres remain below than the US (54K+), EU & UK (23K+), and China (449+). This gap is also a growth lever. As capacity expands, India can scale data-resident, trust-first AI domestically and export those playbooks globally

Where India Can Build Its Next Advantage

Capital Is Backing Execution: Over 80% ($1.6 Bn) of AI startup funding is directed to the application layer, signalling investor conviction in commercial outcomes, not just research narratives

Speed Is Strategic: 91% Of Indian leaders prioritise deployment speed in "buy vs build" decisions. This creates a founder advantage: win by shipping workflows and agents that plug into real operations

Software Is The Growth Flywheel: Software and IT services are the fastest-growing segment in India's AI market, projected to expand at a 64% CAGR from 2025 to 2030. This positions India to lead the next wave of Software-as-a-Service globally

India's Consumer AI Opportunity Is Defined By Reach And Distribution

India has already solved for reach and adoption in consumer AI. The next phase is converting scale into sustainable monetisation, enabled by enterprise-grade software and cloud infrastructure.

India is entering a decisive phase in its AI journey. Consumer adoption is already at global scale, while monetisation and product depth are still evolving.

Unlike mature markets where revenue precedes reach, India's consumer AI story is unfolding in reverse. This creates a window to build durable, mass-market AI products as underlying enterprise AI infrastructure scales.

Why India's Consumer AI Opportunity Is Compelling

Population-Scale Adoption: 886 Mn+ internet users with deep engagement across OTT, social, and messaging platforms

AI Usage Is Already Global-Scale: 177 Mn AI app downloads in 2024, second only to the US

Monetisation Remains Early: ~$12 Mn in consumer in-app spend highlights a wide usage-to-revenue gap

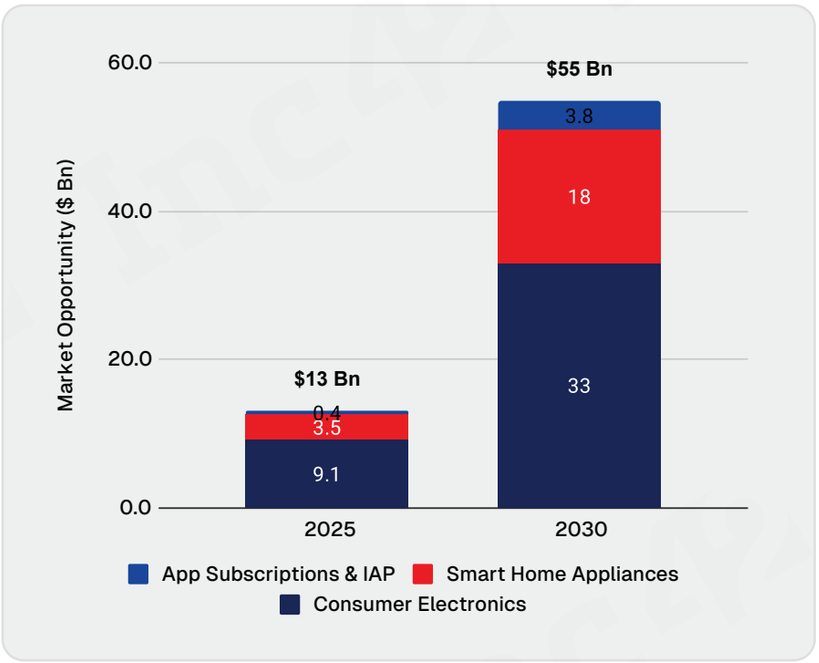
Distribution Is Largely Solved: Existing platforms enable rapid reach, iteration, and feature rollout

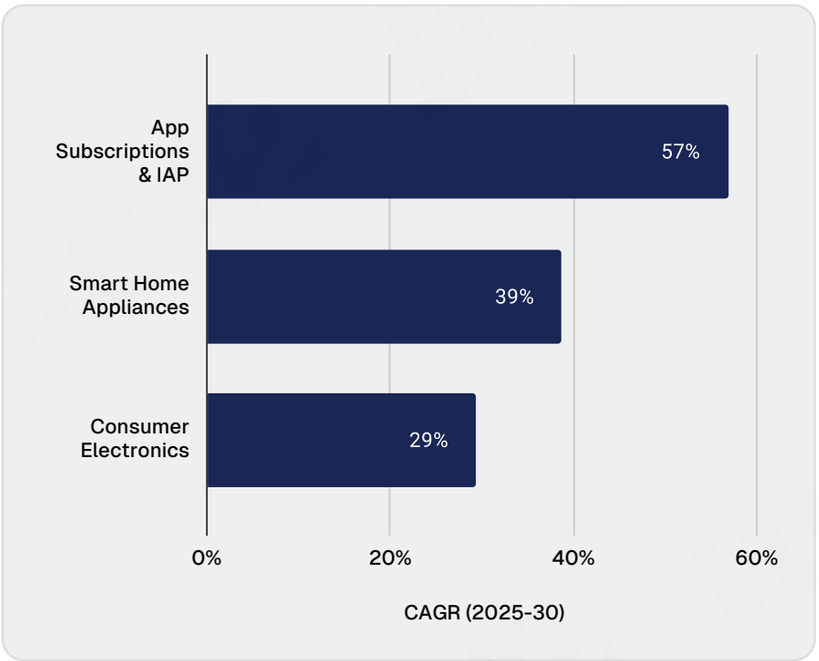
Parameters	Active Internet Users	% Share Of Active Internet Users
Total Users	886 Mn+	100%
OTT (Audio & Video)	732 Mn+	83%
Communication	666 Mn+	75%
Social Media	655 Mn+	74%
Online Gaming	476 Mn+	54%
Net Commerce (Product & Services Ecommerce)	480 Mn+	54%
Digital Payments	405 Mn+	46%
Online Shoppers (Product Ecommerce)	332 Mn+	37%
Power Shoppers (Online)*	18 Mn+	2%

Source: Inc42 Analysis, IAMAI, Kantar
Note: *Power shoppers refers to individuals who place 50 or more orders per year on ecommerce platforms

Subscriptions Will Be Consumer AI's Fastest-Growing Revenue Engine

India's consumer AI market is projected to grow from $13 Bn in 2025 to $55 Bn in 2030, a 4.2x expansion. Consumer electronics remain the largest pool at $33 Bn, while the fastest growth comes from recurring revenue through app subscriptions and in-app purchases.





Where Consumer AI Spend Accumulates By 2030

Consumer Electronics (60% of the market): AI becomes a default layer in smartphones and wearables, pushing stickiness, ecosystem lock-in, and always-on use cases

Smart Home Appliances: A steady upgrade cycle as "connected" becomes "autonomous", expanding paid service

App Subscriptions & IAP: The growth engine as India moves from "trial users" to repeat, paying users for high-utility outcomes

Where Growth Comes From (CAGR, 2025–30)

App Subscriptions & IAP: 57% CAGR (fastest)

Smart Home Appliances: 39% CAGR

Consumer Electronics: 29% CAGR

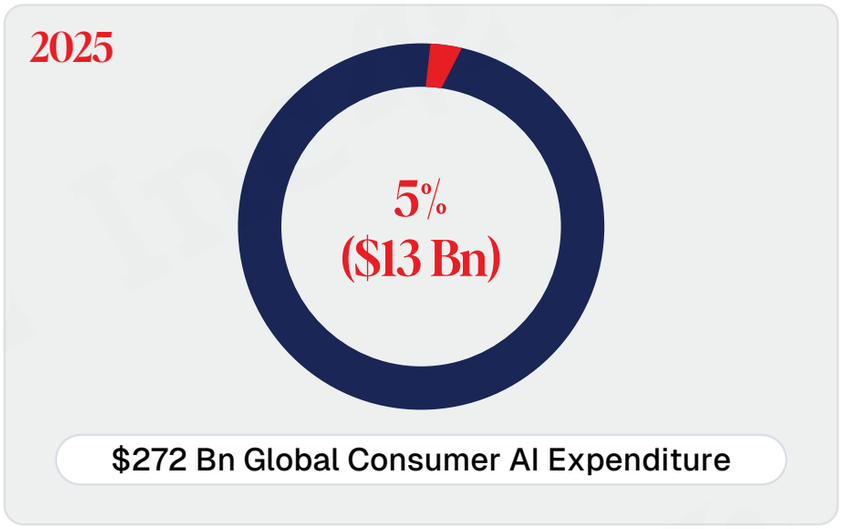
"The monetisation unlock is habit, not novelty, with subscriptions and IAP converting usage into recurring revenue

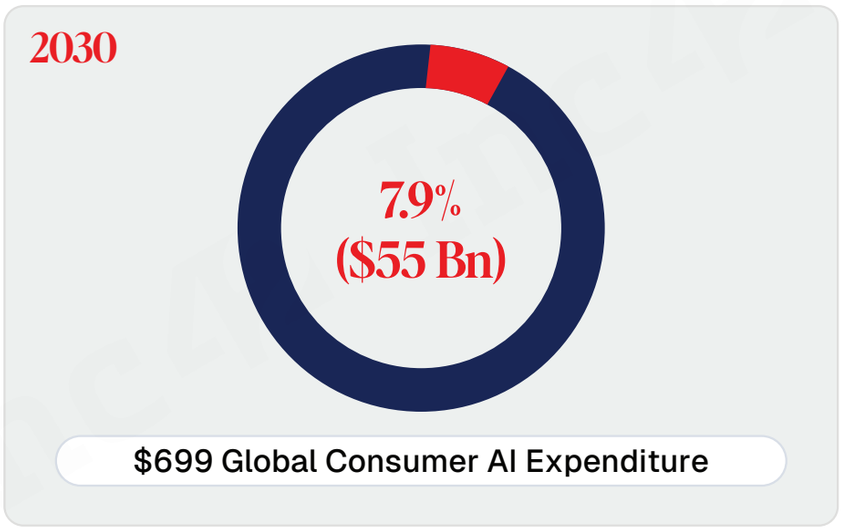
Source: Inc42 Analysis
Note: The market opportunity presented reflects only enterprise spending on AI solutions and excludes consumer AI spending, IAP stands for In-App Purchases

Consumer AI Is India's Next Monetisation Curve

India is the world's second-largest market for AI app downloads, with 177 Mn in 2024, accounting for 23% of downloads across the top five markets. This creates a live, high-frequency environment to build, localise and monetise consumer AI at population scale.

India's Share Of Global Consumer AI Market





Source: Inc42 Analysis, Counterpoint (Global Data), World Economic Forum

Where India Can Lead

Scale As A Strategic Reset: India already leads on usage, with a $13 Bn consumer AI market in 2025. This gives founders a large funnel to learn what converts

Software-as-a-Service Demand: In mature markets, AI often starts with writing and creation. In India, the pull is towards getting work done across bookings, support, commerce and payments, making task-completing AI a natural consumer path

Diversity As The Global Stress Test: If a consumer AI product works across languages, dialects, and low-bandwidth conditions, it becomes export-ready by design

Consumption-Powered Tailwinds: With household consumption at 60% of GDP and a growing middle class, India has the conditions to build habit-forming consumer AI that can sustain paid models

Where India Can Build Its Next Advantage

Revenue Share Is Set To Rise: India's share of global consumer AI spend moves from 5% ($13 Bn) to 7.9% ($55 Bn) by 2030, positioning India as a meaningful value pool

Recurring Revenue Is The Real Unlock: As consumer AI moves from "free trial" to "premium subscription", usage can translate into predictable revenue

Build Moats Through High-Frequency Data: The winners can build data flywheels from everyday consumer behaviour that global players can't replicate locally

Trust Converts In Consumers: Privacy-first, data-resident design and clear guardrails won't just reduce risk, they'll improve conversion, retention, and long-term category leadership

India Can Lead In Outcome-Led Enterprise AI

In India, buyers pay for outcomes: reduced risk, improved revenue and automated operations. This is where founders can win fastest by shipping agentic workflows.

Sector	Adoption Reality	Budget Readiness	Build Opportunities
BFSI	Moving Beyond Chatbots Into Fraud, Underwriting, Compliance	High And Recurring (Risk & Regulation-Driven)	• **Outcome-Led AI That Banks Will Fund:** Reduce fraud loss, improve approval rates, cut turnaround time — sell risk and cost outcomes, not "features" • **Credit For The 'Invisible':** Thin-file underwriting and alternative data workflows that unlock new-to-credit growth without inflating up NPAs • **Compliance At Scale:** KYC and AML automation with auditability and explainability built in, where regulation converts into recurring spend • **Agentic Operations:** Disputes, collections and claims triage that plug into back-office systems and show measurable savings within weeks
Enterprise SaaS	Ai Is Shifting From "Add-On" Features To Core Workflow Layer	High (Productivity & Margin Pressure)	• **Agents Inside Workflows:** Support, sales, finance, and IT operations Build products that do the job, not just assist the user • **Defensible Data Loops:** Turn day-to-day enterprise usage into proprietary feedback that improves accuracy, routing, and automation over time • **Software-as-a-Service Exports:** Package India's operations maturity into repeatable tools that sell into global value pools • **Faster Time-To-Value:** Win on deployment speed and adoption through integrations, onboarding and controls, not model novelty
Manufacturing (Emerging)	Early Scaling Via Predictive Maintenance, Quality, & Energy Optimisation	ROI-Linked (Buyers Fund What Pays Back)	• **Predictive Maintenance That Pays For Itself:** Use Sensor and machine data to cut unplanned downtime, extend asset life, and reduce spare-part waste — a ROI story operations teams will fund • **Quality At Scale:** Use vision and anomaly detection to catch defects early, reduce rework and scrap, and improve yields, especially in high-throughput lines • **Energy & Throughput Optimisation:** Build control layers that tune parameters in real time to lower energy costs and improve output consistency • **Digital Twins For New Factories:** Use greenfield capacity as an advantage by building AI-first plants without legacy system drag, and standardising playbooks across sites • **Supply-Chain Resilience Workflows:** Forecasting, inventory balancing, and supplier risk monitoring as "Software-as-a-Service" inside ERP/MES stacks • **Export-Ready Compliance:** Traceability, audit logs, and automated documentation for global buyers, turning "compliance burden" into premium contracts and faster onboarding

Source: Inc42 Analysis
Note: This is not an exhaustive list of all sectors influenced by AI, but a representation of select few

India Can Turn AI Adoption Into Daily Utility

India's real-world complexity is the advantage Solve for India across language, price and connectivity constraints, and you build export-grade AI.

Sector	Adoption Reality	Budget Readiness	Build Opportunities
Healthcare	Strong Momentum In Diagnostics & Triage; Workflow Modernisation Accelerating	Measured But Rising (Clinical Proof & Approvals)	• **Frugal, High-Performance Care AI:** India as the proving ground for diagnostics and triage copilots that scale quality care with limited specialists • **Hospital Operations Automation:** Scheduling, documentation, billing, coding, large, under-digitised workflows where automation converts directly to margin • **Claims And Payer Workflows:** Insurance and TPA automation is a commercial wedge with clear ROI and repeatable deployments • **Patient Support In Local Languages:** Always-on guidance and adherence layers that improve outcomes and reduce call-centre load
Education (Emerging)	Rapid Iteration In Personalisation & Vernacular Learning	Consumer-Led (Willingness To Pay Is Shows Up In Measurable Outcomes)	• **Exam-First AI Tutors:** Outcome-linked personalisation where practice, feedback and improvement translate into measurable results • **Teacher Copilots:** Planning, assessment and remediation, a wedge that scales through institutions, not just individual learners • **Vernacular Doubt-Solving At Scale:** High-frequency daily utility that drives retention and habit formation • **Outcome-Based Pricing:** Bundles tied to milestones such as rank improvement, completion and score uplift, rather than generic subscriptions
Agriculture (Emerging)	Government & Ecosystem Rails Accelerating; Advisory Is Scaling	Indirect Budgets Are Large (Government, Insurers, FMCG, & Lenders)	• **Voice-First Farmer Agents:** Low-bandwidth, local-language advisory that works in real field conditions, not lab demos • **Input Optimisation And Pest Intelligence:** Protect yield and reduce spend — the fastest "felt" value for farmers and partners • **Mandi Pricing And Market Linkage:** Decision support that improves realisations and reduces volatility for smallholders • **Monetise Via The Ecosystem:** Lenders, insurers, FMCG and government programmes fund adoption when outcomes are measurable at population scale

Source: Inc42 Analysis
Note: This is not an exhaustive list of all sectors influenced by AI, but a representation of select few

04

THE ENGINES BEHIND INDIA'S AI SCALE

Government-Built Rails Are Powering India's AI Scale

The Indian government is building shared infrastructure and common standards across compute, talent, language, and governance, so startups and enterprises can move faster with lower execution risk.

Initiative	Nodal Agency	Key Focus & Scale	What It Unlocks For Startups
IndiaAI Mission	MeitY	10,370 Cr over 5 years; 38,000+ GPUs; subsidised compute at ~₹65 per hour	Makes AI experimentation viable for startups by lowering compute costs and reducing upfront risk
National Strategy For AI	NITI Aayog	AI for Viksit Bharat 2047; responsible AI governance; ethical guardrails for public	Creates clearer expectations on safety, governance and deployment, helping founders build with confidence in regulated environments
FutureSkills Prime	MeitY & NASSCOM	400K+ professionals reskilled; 25 Mn registered users; 41% women participation	Expands the talent pool beyond metro clusters and improves hiring readiness for AI-first teams
BHASHINI	MeitY (Digital India BHASHINI Division)	22+ Indian languages; 100 Mn+ monthly inferences (2024); voice-first, real-time	Reduces the cost of vernacular AI and helps products reach users across languages, devices and connectivity conditions
AIRAWAT	NITI Aayog & C-DAC	100+ petaflops compute accessible via the National Knowledge Network	Strengthens sovereign compute capacity and supports data-resident R&D for strategic use cases
C-DAC / National Supercomputing Mission (NSM)	C-DAC (MeitY) & DST	Sovereign HPC & AI cloud platform; AIRAWAT AI Supercomputer 13,170 Teraflops	Builds long-term national capability for high-performance AI workloads and reduces dependency on critical research infrastructure

Source: Inc42 Analysis, PIB

IndiaAI Mission: India's Sovereign Rails For AI Ecosystem

The IndiaAI Mission is a 10,370 Cr, five-year initiative built as a shared-rails model. Government enables, while the private sector and academia execute It is designed to create common AI infrastructure that individual startups cannot build alone.

Infrastructure Provisioning

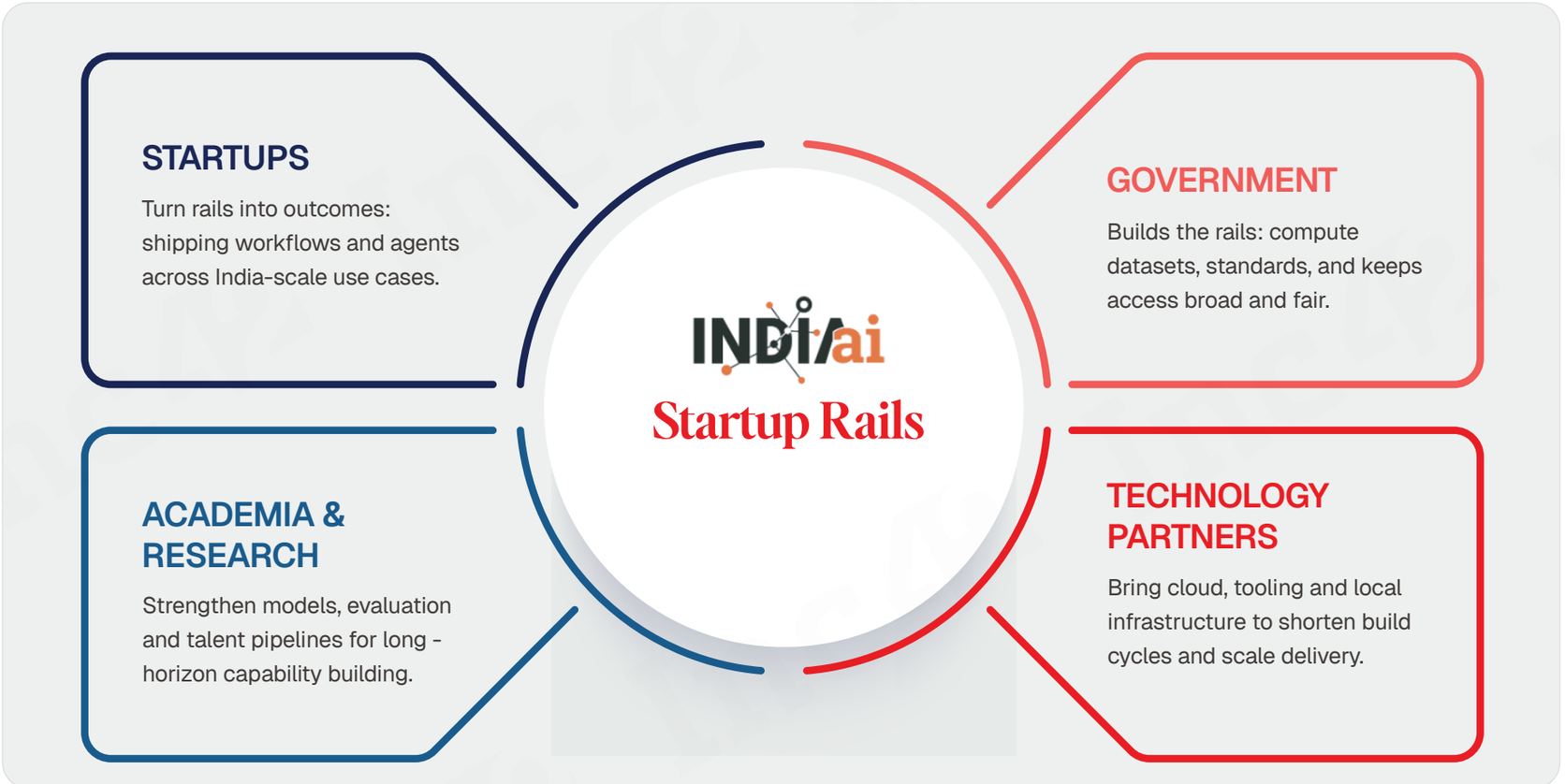
Government is acting as the infrastructure builder by making core inputs available at scale. The mission expands access to compute, data, talent and financing through public–private partnerships with ecosystem players such as Google, Jio and Yotta.

Democratisation By Design

The mission is designed to extend beyond metro clusters, with an explicit focus on Tier II and III cities. This reduces concentration risk, supports distributed innovation and broadens participation beyond "winner-takes-all" access to infrastructure.

Dual Mandate Alignment

IndiaAI links national priorities in agriculture, healthcare, governance and education with startup incentives such as lower costs, IP creation and faster adoption pathways. The intent is to create a reinforcing loop where population-scale outcomes and venture-scale innovation move together.



Seven IndiaAI Pillars Powering Startup Scale

IndiaAI is being built as shared national infrastructure, not a conventional subsidy programme. The intent is to widen access while ensuring startups compete on execution and outcomes, not on who secures scarce compute first.

Pillar	What It Unlocks	Impact
IndiaAI Compute Capacity	Establishing a 10K+ GPU grid (currently 38K+ deployed) through PPP models	**Cuts The "Failure Tax" On Iteration:** Startups can access compute at ₹65/hour versus ₹200+/hour global commercial rates, shifting spend away from infrastructure rent and towards product, R&D, and talent
IndiaAI Innovation Centre	Development of indigenous Large Multimodal Models (LMMs) and foundation models	**Builds Sovereignty Into The Model Layer:** Reduces dependency on Western models that may not reflect India's linguistic and cultural realities, enabling founders to build India-first IP that is harder to replicate
IndiaAI Datasets & Model Platform	A unified hub for high-quality, non-personal anonymised datasets and models	**Turns Data Access Into A Multiplier:** Access to 57K+ government-backed datasets helps startups train and tune models for local sectors such as agriculture and land records, without the time and cost of manual data sourcing and curation
IndiaAI Application Development	Sourcing problem statements from ministries to build sector-specific AI solutions	**Creates A Built-In Early Market:** Aligning solutions to public-sector needs provides a production sandbox and anchor customers, reducing go-to-market friction and improving the odds of scaling beyond pilots
IndiaAI Future Skills	Increasing AI courses (UG, PG, & PhD) and setting up labs in Tier II & III cities	**Decentralises Talent & Execution:** By training ~1 Mn+ professionals, the ecosystem expands beyond Bengaluru and Gurugram, building a larger, distributed talent base for startups to scale faster
IndiaAI Startup Financing	Providing risk capital and SIDBI fund-of-funds support for deeptech AI ventures	**Bridges The "Valley Of Death" For Deeptech**: Patient capital supports longer R&D cycles that traditional venture funding may avoid, allowing high-ambition breakthroughs to mature without premature pressure to monetise
Safe & Trusted AI	Developing tools for bias mitigation, deepfake detection, and ethical guardrails	**Makes Trust An Export Advantage:** Products built within "Safe AI" frameworks are more likely to align with emerging global regulation (eg, EU AI Act), improving enterprise adoption and international readiness

IndiaAI In Action: A Founder Journey From Build To Bharat-Scale

Month 1–2 | Becomes Operable

- Accesses subsidised compute via the national compute grid (Pillar 1)
- Trains on sovereign model infrastructure (eg, Sarvam/BharatGen) (Pillar 2)
- Sources high-quality datasets through AIKosh (Pillar 3)
- Cost reset ~₹5 lakh per month versus ~₹2 Cr per month for comparable experimentation

Month 3–6 | Product Moves From Prototype To Deployable

- Hires from FutureSkills-enabled talent pool (Pillar 5)
- Builds with responsible AI tooling, monitoring, and safety playbooks (Pillar 7)
- Secures application development support to accelerate pilots (Pillar 4)
- Converts a public programme into an anchor deployment and reference case

Month 9–12 | R&D Runway Extends Without Dilution Pressure

- Accesses patient, non-dilutive capital to deepen R&D (Pillar 6)
- Moves from pilot to production-readiness for national roll-outs
- Expands the team and hardens the product through real-world government feedback loops

Month 18–24 | Bharat-Scale Validation & Global Readiness

- Proven at population scale, with compliance and safety built in (Pillar 7)
- Cost structure supports stronger unit economics as the product expands to global markets
- Export-ready, validated under real-world complexity at Bharat scale

1.

   Compute Capacity

   Enhancing processing power for AI tasks

2.

   Innovation Centre

   Fostering research and development in AI

3.

   Datasets Platform (AIKosh)

   Providing access to diverse AI datasets

4.

   Application Development Initiative

   Supporting the creation of AI-driven applications

5.

   FutureSkills

   Equipping the workforce with AI expertise

6.

   Startup Financing

   Providing financial support to AI startups

7.

   Safe & Trusted AI

   Ensuring ethical and secure AI practices

States Are Seeding India's Next AI Hubs

Uttar Pradesh

India's First AI City (70 acres): Dedicated infrastructure for indigenous AI research, R&D centres, and startup ecosystems

Centres Of Excellence (CoEs): AI & ML, Blockchain, 5G & 6G, Drones, Spacetech, Semiconductor Design, Quantum Computing

Global Capability Centres (GCC) Policy 2024: Positioning Lucknow as an advanced R&D centre for multinational emerging-tech functions

Andhra Pradesh

AI City Vizag: Flagship ₹80K Cr ($15 Bn) Google AI Hub planned to anchor the project (2026-2030)

Ratan Tata Innovation Hub (RTIH) Visakhapatnam: Software prototyping facilities, digital twins, an AI model library, a cybersecurity sandbox, 5G testbeds

AI Hub Infrastructure: A 1 GW hyperscale data centre, an international subsea cable gateway and clean-energy integration, reported as a co-development with AdaniConneX and Airtel, supported by the Andhra Pradesh government

Tamil Nadu

Tamil Nadu AI Mission (TNAIM): ₹13.93 Cr allocation for AI research and startup enablement, including Google partnership

Tamil Nadu Emerging Sector Seed Fund (TNESSF): ₹100 Cr anchor investment for frontier tech startups in areas such as AI and semiconductors

₹100 Cr Co-Creation Fund (Fund of Funds): Announced in October 2025 to catalyse venture capital formation

Rajasthan

The Rajasthan AI-ML Policy 2026: Focussed on ethical AI development, government adoption and startup support

State Backed CoEs: Centre of Excellence for AI (CoE-AI) to support research and startups

Startup Incentives: Top-up support through RIPS (Rajasthan Investment Promotion Scheme), aligned with AI and ML initiatives

Source: Inc42 Analysis, Media Reports

States Are Seeding India's Next AI Hubs

Karnataka

State AI Mission (In Planning): A state-specific mission to formalise AI strategy, priority sectors, and innovation programmes

AI In Government Education: Integrating AI-enabled learning tools in government schools to improve learning outcomes

Telangana

AI Curriculum At Scale: AI curricula and learning solutions rolled out across government schools (expanded across districts)

Google Partnership: State-led collaboration with Google to deploy AI solutions across education and agriculture

Maharashtra

MahaAgri-AI Policy (2025–29): Launched with ₹500 Cr to advance AI in agriculture and accelerate innovation

Transport Compliance: AI-enabled geofencing used by the Transport Department to improve the credibility of emissions testing

Governance + Local Language Focus: State signalling emphasis on AI governance and local-language LLMs via recent ecosystem engagements (e.g., AI Impact Summit)

Odisha

Odisha AI Policy (2025): Approved with a dedicated AI Mission to strengthen governance and data-driven public services

Public-Sector Deployments: AI being deployed in public health and agriculture through partnerships (e.g., Wadhwani AI)

Source: Inc42 Analysis, Media Reports

Google Is Becoming A Force Multiplier For India's AI Stack

Google is aligning infrastructure, compliance readiness, capital and developer tooling with India's sovereign AI agenda and the execution realities of Indian founders. The result is lower build friction and faster paths from experimentation to production, with fewer structural bottlenecks for startups and enterprises.

Infrastructure Participation

IndiaAI's public compute programme (August 2025 tender) includes **1,050 Trillium TPUs (6th Gen)**

What It Unlocks: Google's custom silicon is being integrated into India's national compute capacity, broadening the hardware ecosystem beyond reliance on a single dominant architecture Importantly, the deployment of local TPUs ensures that sensitive data remains within India, a crucial factor for government and BFSI sectors

Digital Sovereignty

Google Cloud **Assured Workloads** supports data residency and administrative access controls aligned with the **DPDP Act, 2023**

What It Unlocks: Regulated sectors such as BFSI, healthcare and public services can adopt cloud AI with clearer compliance guardrails

Co-Innovation

Through the AI Futures Fund, the Atoms 2026 cohort (in partnership with Accel) and its accelerator programmes, Google is backing early stage startups with capital and hands-on support

Google's Startup School adds structured virtual mentorship and workshops to help early stage founders scale. With a sharper focus on generative AI, it helps even non-technical founders move from "prompt to prototype" in weeks using tools such as Gemini

What It Unlocks: A stronger Pre-Series A support layer by combining runway, capability-building and execution guidance, increasing the odds of export-ready products built for India's complexity

Technical Viability

Vertex AI and Gemini developer tooling can simplify development workflows and compress build cycles

What It Unlocks: Smaller teams can ship faster, widening the pool of teams that can build and deploy AI production-grade AI

EMBEDDED IN NATIONAL RAILS

IndiaAI, BHASHINI, government apps

BACKING EARLY STAGE STARTUPS

Atoms, founders stake in Google's success

BUILDING SECTOR-SPECIFIC SOLUTIONS

Reliance agents, healthcare, agriculture

EXPANDING DISTRIBUTION

Potential distribution via Reliance Jio bundling, with reach at population scale

Build With India: Google Is Co-Building Across India's AI Stack

Segment	Focus Area	What It Unlocks
Consumer & Scale	**Reliance Jio: "Google AI Pro" Rollout:** In October 2025, Google and Reliance announced 18 months of access to Google AI Pro for Jio 5G subscribers Includes Gemini 25 Pro and 2 TB storage	**Distribution Via Bundling:** By bypassing the "subscription paywall," Google uses Jio's 500 Mn+ user base to make Gemini the default AI interface for the Indian masses, mirroring how Android became the default OS through hardware bundling
Sovereign Infra	**IndiaAI Mission (Compute Tender):** Google secured a key tender to deploy 1,050 Trillium TPUs (6th Gen) into India's national public compute cluster to support researchers and startups	**Hardware Neutrality & Resilience:** Integrating TPUs into the national grid reduces India's "GPU-dependency" on Nvidia It establishes Google's custom silicon as a sovereign-grade alternative for large-scale training
Startup Ecosystem	**Google & Accel (Atoms):** A strategic co-investment programme where Google's AI Futures Fund provides up to $2 Mn in funding and $350K in cloud credits to pre-seed AI startups	**Cap Table Integration:** By backing startups early, Google strengthens long-term alignment with its cloud and developer stack, while founders get runway and go-to-market support
Digital Inclusion	**Project BHASHINI (MeitY):** Google committed $2 Mn to the Indic Language Research Hub at IIT Bombay and released its Gemma open models on the IndiaAI platform	**Language Infrastructure:** This collaboration ensures India's Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) remains vernacular-first It allows the government to deliver AI-driven welfare services in 22+ local languages
Enterprise Adoption	**Reliance Intelligence (Go-to-Market):** Reliance became a strategic partner for Gemini Enterprise, co-developing vertical-specific AI agents for retail, finance, and manufacturing	**Vertical AI Agents:** By leveraging Reliance's sector expertise (Retail/Telecom), Google can deploy "pre-built" AI agents that solve specific Indian enterprise problems, accelerating the transition from "pilot" to "production"
Public Services	**Axis My India (Citizen App):** Collaborated to build and launched, a multilingual super-app using Google's GenAI to help citizens navigate government schemes via voice in local dialects	**Frictionless Governance:** Voice-first interfaces can reduce friction in scheme discovery and access, especially for low-literacy and vernacular users
Agri & Health	**Wadhwani AI & AIIMS (Grants):** Google.org provided $4.5 Mn Mn to Wadhwani AI for agricultural models (Garuda) and supported MedGemma at AIIMS to digitise medical records	**High-Impact Social Validation:** These collaborations push AI into high-impact domains such as health and agriculture, strengthening deployment credibility and real-world learnings

Enabling Faster Enterprise AI Deployment With Lower Build Friction

	Primary Use Case	Deployment Requirement	Google Stack Used	Outcome
Adya	Enterprise AI workflows and multi-agent orchestration	Secure, scalable production workloads with lean engineering capacity	Google Kubernetes Engine (GKE), Vertex AI, Gemini, Virtual Private Cloud (VPC)	• 85% Reduction in fine-tuning costs • 21% Performance improvement vs competitors • 30% Faster time-to-market • 10X Faster orchestration faster
sarvam	Indic language translation and conversational AI	High-accuracy models across India's 22 officially recognised languages at sustainable compute economics	Gemma 3, Google Cloud infrastructure, translation APIs	• 100K+ Weekly translation requests • 10 Mn+ Conversation turns • Lower training and inference costs for Indic languages • Improved token efficiency for Indian-language text
CoRover.ai	Multilingual conversational AI for enterprise & public-facing deployments	High accuracy at population scale with data sovereignty and low-latency performance	Gemini on Google Cloud, multilingual capabilities, high-throughput architecture	• 20 Bn+ Interactions processed • 25K+ Enterprise customers • ~99% Accuracy across 100+ languages • 70% Improvement in operational efficiency • ~10X Faster implementation

Shayak Mazumder
Founder, Adya

"Something that used to take us months to do three, four, sometimes ten developer months, today, can be done in one hour or even minutes. The App Studio difference is that other platforms are not able to build agents"

Dr. Pratyush Kumar
Founder, Sarvam AI

"[Gemma] breaks down Indian language text into fewer tokens on average, which directly improves the model's ability to represent and learn from these languages efficiently"

Vikas T
VP - Product & Tech, CoRover AI

"We have the privilege of talking to Google's DeepMind team, where we are working on Gemma. Google has been instrumental right from getting the access to models, also getting engineering support, Cloud credits and what not!"

Producing Creator-Grade Generative Media Production At Speed

	Primary Use Case	Deployment Requirement	Google Stack Used	Outcome
invideo AI	Text-to-video generation for ads, explainers, story-led content	Consistent video, audio and scripts without multi-tool complexity	Gemini, Imagen 4, Veo 3	• **Automates** the workflow from prompt to output • **Reduces** technical set-up and integration overhead • **Enables** non-technical users to create long-form video content
DASHVERSE	AI-led storytelling and rapid content production	High-quality visual storytelling at speed, without specialised production teams	Veo 3, Lyria 2 (Via Vertex AI), Gemini	• **Accelerates** creation of generative media experiences • **Enables** rapid production of vibe-led content formats through Veo 3 for a 90-minute Indian mythology epic, with responsive soundtracks via Lyria 2

Sanket Shah
Cofounder & CEO, invideo

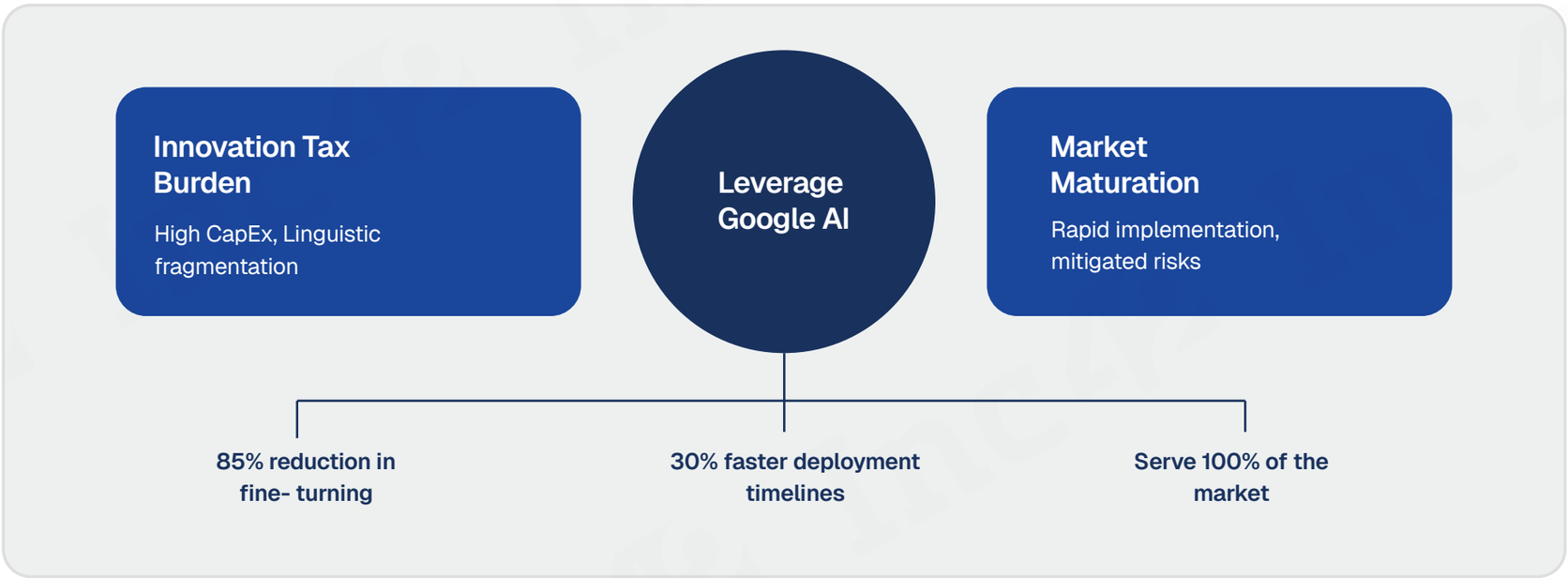
"Our collaboration with Google Cloud allows us to utilise Google's leading AI models, providing creators with powerful yet user-friendly video editing capabilities. Working with Google helps us deliver new kinds of video quality faster."

Sanidhya Narain
CEO, Dashverse

"Google Play has been a strong supporter in building global alliances, such as our partnership with the Korean Webtoon Ecosystem and facilitating our joint event for Indian creators at WAVES 2025. On the technology front, Google Cloud has empowered Frameo with access to cutting-edge models, including Nano Banana and Gemini."

Google's AI Stack Is Compressing Build-To-Production Cycle & Costs

Across cost, language and execution complexity, Google's stack shortens the path from experimentation to production at Bharat scale.



What Changes In Production

Economic Viability Improves

AI development shifts from heavy upfront spend to a more manageable operating model

Evidence: **Adya AI reported 85% lower fine-tuning costs, improving runway and iteration capacity**

Vernacular Capability Becomes A Growth Lever

Multilingual performance moves from localisation overhead to product advantage

Evidence: **22+ languages supported, 100K+ weekly translation requests, and 10 Mn+ conversation turns (Sarvam AI)**

Execution Velocity Becomes A Differentiator

Tooling maturity reduces build friction and compresses time-to-production

Evidence: **30% faster time-to-market (Adya AI) and up to 10X faster implementation (CoRover)**

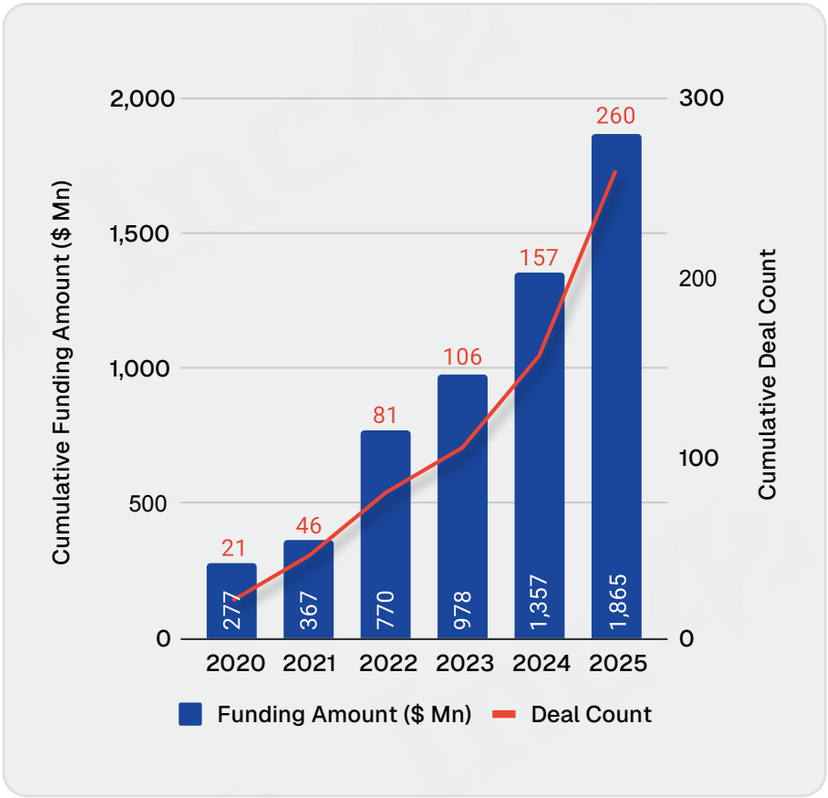
Population-Scale Readiness Is Proven

Systems are being stress-tested at high volume across diverse user conditions

Evidence: **20 Bn+ interactions processed, ~99% accuracy across 100+ languages and 25K+ enterprise customers (CoRover)**

India's Native AI Startups Attracted Over $1.8 Bn Funding

Venture funding into Indian AI startups has surged over the past five years. But capital is concentrated in applications (~86%) rather than infrastructure and foundation layers, accelerating commercialisation while increasing long-term dependency risk.



- $1.8 Bn+ raised by Indian AI startups since 2020
- ~86% funding has flowed to application-layer startups
- ~9 in 10 funded startups are application-led
- 69% of funded AI startups are at seed stage
- Bengaluru remains the centre of gravity, but specialised hubs are emerging

Geographic Shift Towards Specialised Hubs

- **Bengaluru:** Mature ecosystem and global export pathways
- **Hyderabad:** GovTech & compliance-led AI is emerging
- **Pune:** Industrial AI hubs are forming (manufacturing & Industry 4.0

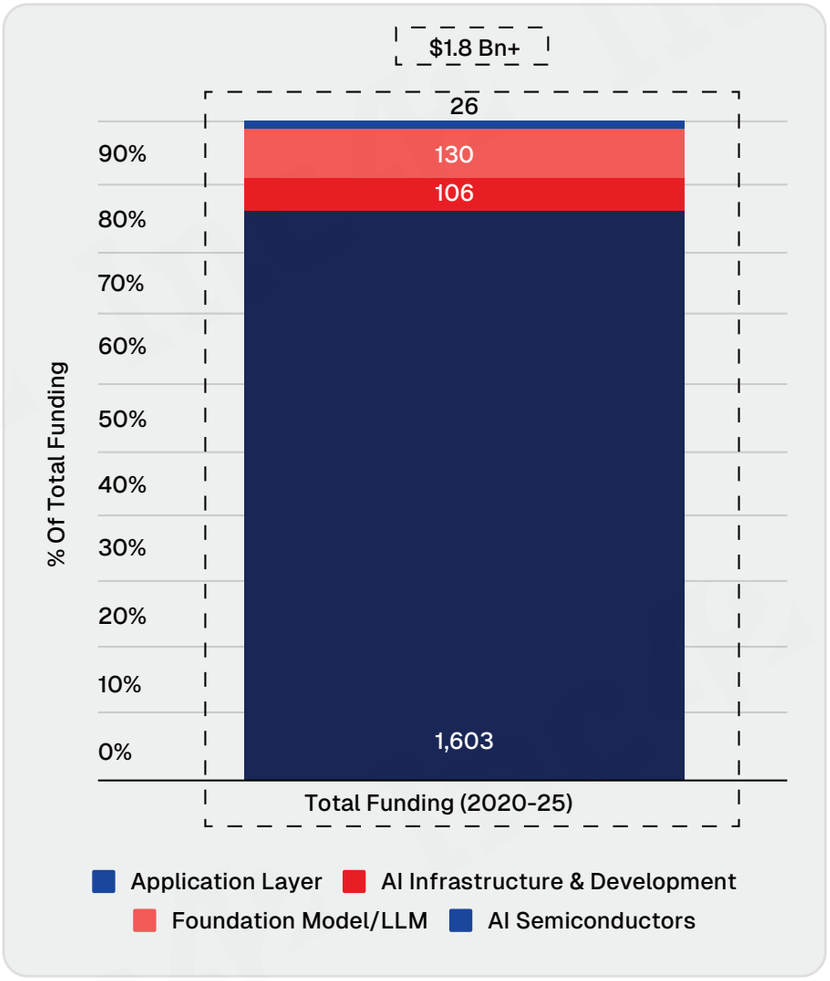
Signals From Founders & Investors

- 94% of non-AI founders view AI as a strategic priority
- 40% of investors expect AI to drive the next wave of unicorns
- 69% of funded AI startups at seed stage, runway pressure, acceleration expected

Source: Inc42
Note: This analysis is based on funding transactions recorded in the Inc42 database from 2020 to November 2025

India's AI Bets Are Mostly Application-Led

Application-Layer Startups Capture Over 80% Of AI Funding In India



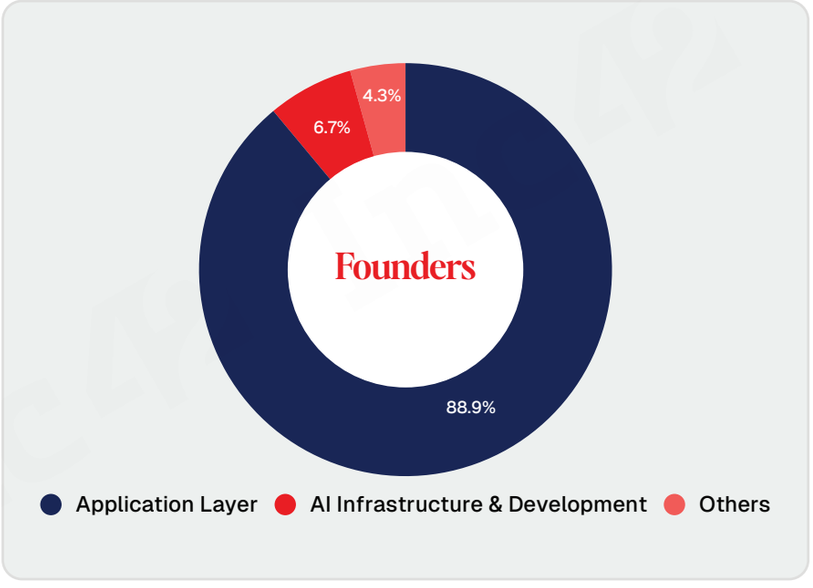
Application-Led Focus: India's AI capital has concentrated in commercial applications (~$1.6 Bn), accelerating shipping and adoption. The long-term question is whether infrastructure and foundation-layer investment can scale fast enough to avoid persistent dependency

Infrastructure As Strategic Control: With only ~$106 Mn invested in AI infrastructure, India remains reliant on external cloud and compute platforms. Expanding domestic capacity is the clearest lever to reduce costs, improve resilience and strengthen autonomy

Foundation Models Are Still Underfunded: Just ~$130 Mn in foundation model funding signals an early stage research base. Closing the gap will require stronger academia–industry collaboration to build domain and language-native models aligned to India's sector needs

"As global AI stacks become protectionist, India's application-focused ecosystem creates unique opportunity: vertically-integrated AI (eg, BFSI agents, healthcare diagnostics) that blends commercial speed with defensible IP, positioning for global exports before foundation models consolidate

Nearly 90% Of Funded Startups Are Application-Led

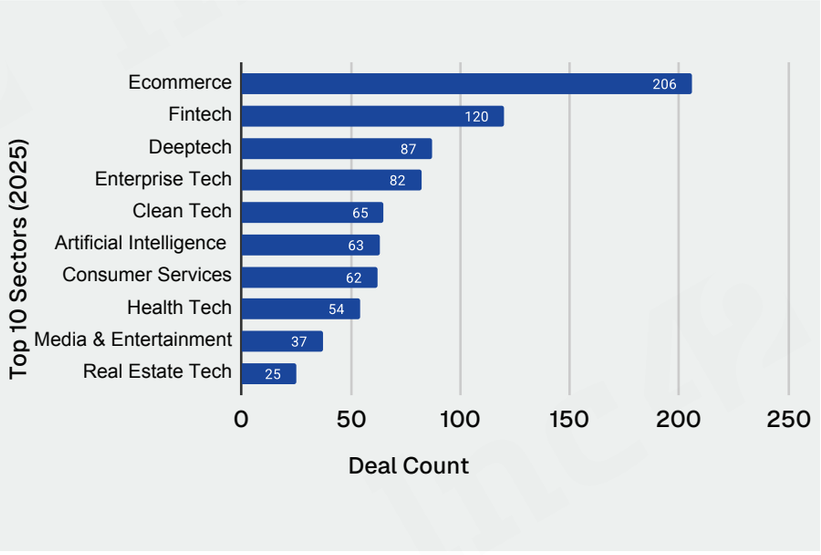


Source: Inc42
Note: This analysis is based on funding transactions recorded in the Inc42 database from 2020 to November 2025

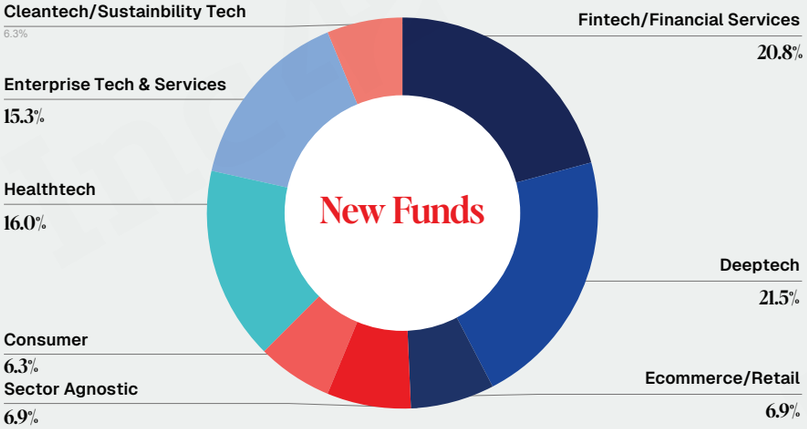
Deeptech Moved From A Niche To A Funding Mainstay In 2025

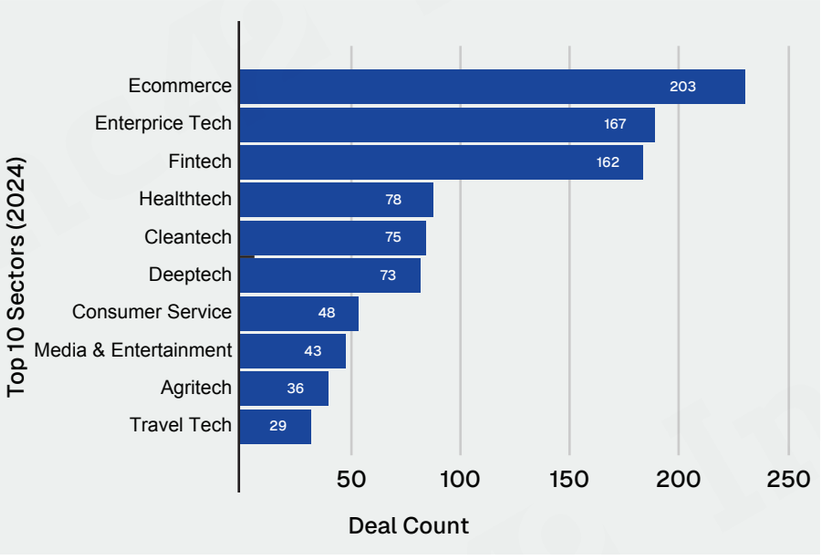
In 2025, deeptech emerged as the third-most funded sector by deal volume, signalling strong early stage momentum. While it ranked seventh by total funding value, the deal intensity shows broad-based seed and early-growth activity. Fund formation reinforces this shift: 31 of 90 funds announced in 2025 cite deeptech as a mandate, signalling that deeptech is moving from episodic bets to institutional capital allocation.

Deeptech Entered India's Top Three Funded Startup Sectors In 2025



Deeptech Is The Most Common Sector Focus Among Funds Announced In 2025





Government Initiatives

~ ₹3,533 Cr invested in 220 deeptech startups under SIDBI Fund of Funds

₹10,371 Cr outlay for IndiaAI Mission to build AI infrastructure and ecosystem, with ₹2,000 Cr sanctioned for 2025-26

₹6,003 Cr National Quantum Mission to scale R&D and industry in quantum computing, communication, sensing and materials, with ₹17.02Cr disbursed so far (as of mid-2025)

₹1,000 Cr IN-SPACe Space VC Fund, operationalised in late 2025 through an agreement with SIDBI Venture Capital Limited

Source: Inc42
Note: Data as of 20 December, 2025 | Based on analysis of funds announced / closed / partially closed in 2025

AI / Deeptech Focussed Funds Announced In 2025

Name	Corpus	Stage Focus	Sectors Covered
BOUNDLESS VENTURES	$225 Mn	Early Stage	AI Native
IIT Madras Alumni Association	$225 Mn	Early Stage	Deeptech
SPECIALE INVEST	$155 Mn	Growth Stage	Deeptech
Activate capital	$75 Mn	Early Stage	AI
GOOD CAPITAL	$30 Mn	Early Stage	AI
BYT CAPITAL	$20 Mn	Early Stage	Deeptech
RICEBERG VENTURES	$20 Mn	Early Stage	Deeptech
888vc	$19 Mn	Early Stage	AI, Deeptech

Source: Inc42
Note: This is not an exhaustive list | Data as of 20 December, 2025 | Based on analysis of funds announced / closed / partially closed in 2025

Funds With AI / Deeptech As One Of The Key Focus

Name	Corpus	Stage Focus	Sectors Covered
nexus venture partners	$700 Mn	Early Stage	AI, Enterprise Tech, Consumer Services, Fintech
Accel	$650 Mn	Early Stage	AI, Consumer Tech, Fintech, Manufacturing
Bessemer Venture Partners	$350 Mn	Early Stage	AI, SaaS, Fintech, Digital Health, Consumer Brands, Cybersecurity
BLUME	$275 Mn	Early Stage	Consumer, Fintech, Healthtech, Deeptech
NORTH POINT CAPITAL	$155 Mn	Early Stage	AI, Financial Services, Logistics, Healthcare, Manufacturing, Consumer Products
chiratae VENTURES	$150 Mn	Early Stage	AI, Deeptech, Healthtech, Spacetech
YALI CAPITAL Deep Tech Fund	$103 Mn	Early Stage	Chip Design, Robotics, Genomics, Smart Manufacturing, Aerospace, AI
EXPERT	$100 Mn	Early Stage	Fintech, B2B, SaaS, AI
PRIME VENTURE PARTNERS	$100 Mn	Early Stage	Fintech, AI, SaaS

Source: Inc42
Note: This is not an exhaustive list | Data as of 20 December, 2025 | Based on analysis of funds announced / closed / partially closed in 2025

Investors Backing India's AI Wave

Investor Name	AI Startups Backed
100X Funding Simplified	Anyway.ai, WhiteTable.ai, Datavio, GoCodeo AI
3ONE4 CAPITAL	Blend, Fego AI, Nektar AI
Accel	Finbots.ail, Nanonets, Nurix AI, Spyne
ALL IN	Segmind, Magic Studio, Suitable AI
ANTLER	Figr Design, Tradomate.one, Plotch.ai, Segwise AI
ARKA VENTURE LABS	Enkrypt AI, RagaAI, Daxa.ai, BrieflyAI
BLUME	Agara, Kusho.ai, Segwise AI, SiftHub
chiratae VENTURES	Expertia AI, Lightbulb.ai, Locale.ai, Pixis AI
ELEVATION	Drivetrain.ai, Factors.ai, Murf AI
Endiya	Myelin Foundry, Expertia AI, Slang Labs
ENTREPRENEUR FIRST	Beatovenai, vidyoai, expertiaai
FIRSTCHEQUE	Dubpro.ai, Inspekt Labs, Predis.ai
Google for Startups	AiSteth, ORBO AI, PhotAI, Vaani AI, VideoSDK

Source: Inc42
Note: This is not an exhaustive list nor a ranking of any kind

Investor Name	AI Startups Backed
Indian Angel Network	OnFinance AI, AuraML, Skit AI, Uniphore
IIMA Ventures	Kosha AI, Axai AI, Clodura.AI, vPhrase
IndiaQuotient	Llumo AI, Maino.ai
Inflection Point Ventures	Alchemyst AI, LiaPlus AI
Inflexor	Ayna, Vitra.ai, Awiros
infoedge	Gnani.ai, Dview.io, Hyperbots, Convin, Haptik
kalaari capital	Eightfold AI, Qure.ai, NextBillion.ai
Lightspeed	SiftHub, Peoplebox.ai, Peopleboxai, Mugafi, OnFinance AI
Mars Shot VC	Neysa, Observe.AI, Neuron7.ai
nexus venture partners	Qure.ai, InVideo, SamyaAI
peak xv	CodeKarma, Llumo AI, CureSkin, Irame AI, Contineu
SenseAI Ventures	Genylabs, Fego.ai, Peptris Technologies
Speciale Invest	Vodex AI, Boxx AI, Kluisz.ai, Netrasemi
Unicorn India Ventures	CoRover AI, Plotch.ai, Dubpro.ai
VentureCatalysts India's 1st Multi-Stage VC	Leena AI, Nanonets, Observe.AI, RedBrick AI
Y Combinator	GreyLabs AI, SiftHub, Krutrim
Z47 (fka Matrix Partners India)	AiSteth, ORBO AI, Phot.ai, Vaani AI, VideoSDK

Source: Inc42
Note: This is not an exhaustive list nor a ranking of any kind

Innovation Tax Is Falling Across Infrastructure, Execution And Capital

IndiaAI rails and ecosystem stacks are reducing build friction across compute, data, language, deployment and trust. In parallel, capital is aligning towards application-led outcomes and deeptech mandates.

What Historically Held India Back	What's Changing Now	Evidence
Compute Economics: Global GPU pricing (₹200+ per hour) made serious experimentation CapEx-heavy and metro-concentrated	**Compute Becomes Usable:** Subsidised access (~₹65/hour) shifts experimentation into an OpEx-friendly iteration loop	IndiaAI subsidised compute pricing; expanded national compute access
Language Complexity: 22+ languages meant parallel product, model and QA cycles, multiplying build time and cost	**Language Becomes A Growth Lever:** Indic tooling and models reduce localisation overhead and compress build cycles	BHASHINI; Indic model ecosystem (eg Sarvam/BharatGen)
Data Readiness: High-quality datasets were fragmented, expensive and slow to operationalise	**Data Becomes Usable:** Shared, anonymised datasets reduce rebuild costs and speed up training and validation	AIKosh; 1,200+ anonymised datasets)
Talent Concentration: Breakthrough teams clustered in a few metro corridors, limiting founder participation and hiring depth	**Talent Spreads Beyond Metros:** Tier II & III pipeline expands the hiring base beyond metro hubs	FutureSkills expansion (towards a 1 Mn+ professional pipeline target)
Capital Mismatch: Deeptech timelines rarely fit conventional venture cycles, widening the prototype-to-scale "valley of death"	**Patient Capital Expanding:** Equity-free support extends R&D runway without forcing premature commercialisation	₹2,000 Cr equity-free funding support direction
Net Effect: Many potential deeptech founders were priced out early, pushing talent and IP towards global centres	**Net Effect:** Access widens and iteration speeds up, allowing founders to build for Bharat-scale adoption without clearing infrastructure barriers first	Compounding impact of compute, data, language, talent, capital rails

05

TRUST IS BECOMING THE DEFINING MOAT

Democratisation AI Access Elevates Trust A Competitive Moat

Historically, India's AI landscape was shaped by an "innovation tax" — structural barriers that made early experimentation expensive, slow and team-heavy. As AI becomes easier to build, the harder problem shifts to deployment: reliability, safety and governance in production, especially at Bharat scale. India is a unique proving ground — if a system can perform across India's linguistic diversity and real-world edge cases, it is more likely to travel globally In this cycle, trust moves from a principle to a competitive moat.

Between 2020 and 2024, moving from prototype to production-grade AI was gated by three constraints:

Capital Intensity: The CapEx Barrier

Training or even piloting LLMs required high-performance multi-GPU clusters, often **costing ₹6,000–₹8,000/hour.** For teams building proprietary infrastructure, a single high-performance server typically **required ₹40–₹60 lakh upfront,** effectively reserving serious iteration for well-funded players.

Linguistic Chaos: The Complexity Multiplier

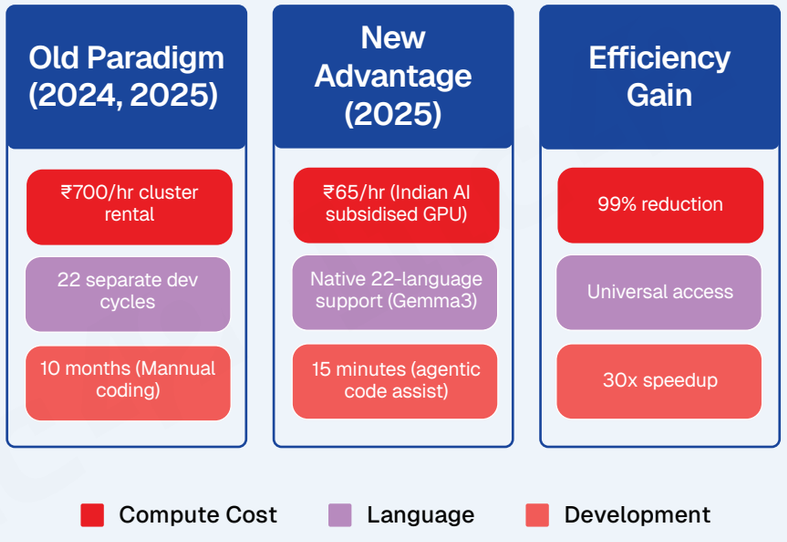
India's 22 official languages functioned as a development multiplier. **Each additional language created new build cycles** — datasets, tokenisation choices, QA loops and edge cases — **increasing technical debt and time-to-market.**

Talent Scarcity: The Minimum Viable Team

Running multilingual AI in production demanded a **"heavy" team model —** often **10+ specialised engineers** across data engineering, ML research and MLOps — a threshold that priced out many early stage founders.

As build constraints loosen and AI access widens, technical execution stops being the scarce advantage. The next edge is trust — proving safety, reliability and governance in production, at India scale.

Speed unlocked. Barriers Removed: The 2025 Efficiency Leap



The Two Layers Powering India's AI Scale-Up

India's next phase depends on capability and trust maturing together. One expands access to compute, data and language infrastructure. The other builds privacy, safety, auditability and fairness Without capability, AI stays expensive and concentrated. Without trust, AI stays stuck in pilots.

	Capability Layer	Trust Layer
Primary Role	Lowers the innovation tax and expands who can build and ship	Converts adoption into durable, production-grade deployment
What It Unlocks	Faster iteration, lower cost-to-experiment, wider participation beyond metros	Enterprise confidence, regulated adoption, repeatable outcomes at scale
Core Building Blocks	Compute access and capacity Shared datasets and data availability (eg, AIKosh), language infrastructure and Indic interfaces (eg, BHASHINI) Skilling, innovation hubs, ecosystem programme	Privacy and data governance (DPDP-aligned practices), safety and reliability controls (testing, red-teaming, monitoring), fairness and inclusion across languages and user groups, auditability and accountability (logs, documentation, transparency)
Where It Shows Up First	Prototype-to-production speed, developer velocity, early startup formation	Pilot-to-production conversion, procurement readiness and fewer rollbacks
Most Critical For	Building and scaling AI products efficiently	Deploying AI in high-stakes sectors (BFSI, healthcare, public services)
Failure Mode If Weak	AI remains expensive and concentrated, and innovation stays narrow	AI remains stuck in pilots, and adoption stalls in regulated workflows
Bottom-Line Outcome	Scale becomes possible	Scale becomes durable

India's Responsible AI Advantage

As capability expands, trust decides who deploys at scale. India's Responsible AI approach reduces uncertainty for buyers while raising the baseline on governance, safety and reliability.

Dimension	INDIA	EU / US	Why It Matters
Privacy Baseline	DPDP Act 2023 Act and DPDP Rules (2025) set an enforceable privacy and consent baseline	EU has GDPR, while the US remains sectoral and state-led	A clearer baseline reduces buyer uncertainty and speeds enterprise roll-outs
AI Governance Posture	India AI Governance Guidelines (2025) signal a framework-led, capacity-building approach	EU is compliance-led, while the US is standards-led	Enables experimentation while setting guardrails for safer deployment
Trust Infrastructure	IndiaAI's Safe and Trusted AI pillar positions trust tooling as shared rails for the ecosystem	Trust tooling is largely vendor-led or sector-specific	Shared rails reduce duplicated compliance work and shorten enterprise security reviews
Complexity At Scale	High linguistic, cultural, and operational variance across users and contexts	More uniform deployment contexts	Systems proven here are more resilient and often more export-ready by design

Trust Becomes The Moat In India's AI Build Cycle

In the rush to deploy, responsible AI is often treated as compliance. In India, it is emerging as a strategic moat: in a low-trust, high-noise digital environment, verified safety becomes a differentiator and a prerequisite for adoption in regulated and mass-market use cases.

As the innovation tax falls, the build phase becomes more accessible and more competitive. Technical execution is no longer the only differentiator; trust is Products that stay safe and reliable across India's real-world complexity — languages and dialects, low-bandwidth conditions, noisy data, and population-scale usage — become export-ready by design.

Five Pillars Of India's Trust Framework

Ethical Foundation & Governance

"Do no harm" embedded into product decisions from day one

Data Sovereignty & Privacy

Consent-led practices aligned with DPDP and India-first controls

Algorithmic Fairness

Bias detection and mitigation for India-relevant user diversity (caste, region, religion, gender)

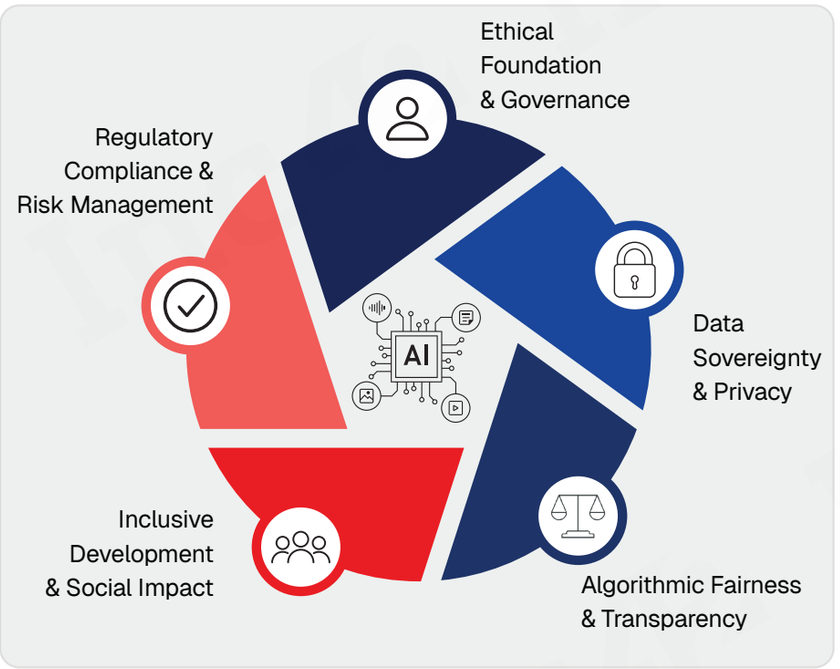
Inclusive Development

Bharat-first design that works across language, literacy, and connectivity constraints

Compliance Readiness

Audit-ready controls that shorten enterprise reviews and speed procurement sign-off

India's Responsible AI Framework Data



As India's AI market scales to $126 Bn by 2030, responsible AI shifts startups from shipping features to earning trust — improving enterprise readiness, accelerating adoption, and strengthening long-term defensibility

The Trust-by-Design Playbook

A five-pillar operating model that converts trust expectations into build discipline, deployment readiness, and auditability.

Pillar	Core Principle	Examples	What Startups Should Implement
Ethical Foundation & Governance	Decision-grade governance that makes AI traceable and approvable, shortening enterprise risk reviews and speeding sign-off	NITI Aayog (Responsible AI principles) MeitY (India AI Governance Guidelines, 2025)	● **Assign decision owners** (Product, Model, Risk) for high-impact use cases, with a clear escalation path and approval matrix ● **Maintain a decision and change log** (use case, data sources, model version, rationale, approvals) that is audit-ready ● **Ship a buyer-ready trust pack** with model cards, usage boundaries, human override, and a documented user redress process
Data Sovereignty & Privacy	DPDP-aligned, data-resident controls that remove "data risk" objections early and unlock regulated deployments faster	DPDP Act 2023 and DPDP Rules (2025) Google Cloud Assured Workloads (in-country controls)	● **Map data flows end-to-end** (collect → process → store → share) with purpose limitation and consent where required ● **Enforce residency and access controls** using encryption, role-based access, vendor and sub-processor controls, and immutable audit logs ● **Operationalise retention and deletion** through retention schedules, deletion/erasure workflows, and incident/breach evidence trails
Algorithmic Fairness	Proven performance across India's diversity that reduces bias risk and increases buyer confidence in production outcomes	RagaAI (testing and evaluation) NIST AI RMF (risk and governance reference)	● **Run slice-based evaluation** across relevant user segments (language, region, context) with defined fairness thresholds ● **Complete pre-deployment safety and bias testing**, including adversarial checks, and mandate human review for sensitive decisions ● **Publish measurable proof for buyers** using a fairness report plus a monitoring plan (what is tracked, thresholds, escalation)
Inclusive Development	Bharat-ready design that works across language, literacy, and connectivity constraints, expanding reach and improving activation and retention	BHASHINI (language DPI) CoRover (multilingual deployments)	● **Deliver multilingual and multimodal UX** (voice where appropriate) with clear fallback paths ● **Optimise for low bandwidth and low-end devices** (latency, payload size, offline-first flows where relevant) ● **Validate with diverse user testing across regions and socio-economic segments**, and bake learnings into release cycles
Compliance As A Sales Accelerator	Audit-ready monitoring, incident readiness, and traceability that shortens security reviews and speeds procurement sign-off	IndiaAI "Safe and Trusted AI" pillar Qureai (clinical-grade deployments)	● **Classify use cases by risk tier and map controls accordingly** (access, human-in-loop, explainability, data handling) ● **Monitor drift, safety,** and bias metrics with defined thresholds and alerts ● **Maintain incident response playbooks and an audit-ready evidence trail**

Responsible AI Best Practices For Indian Startups

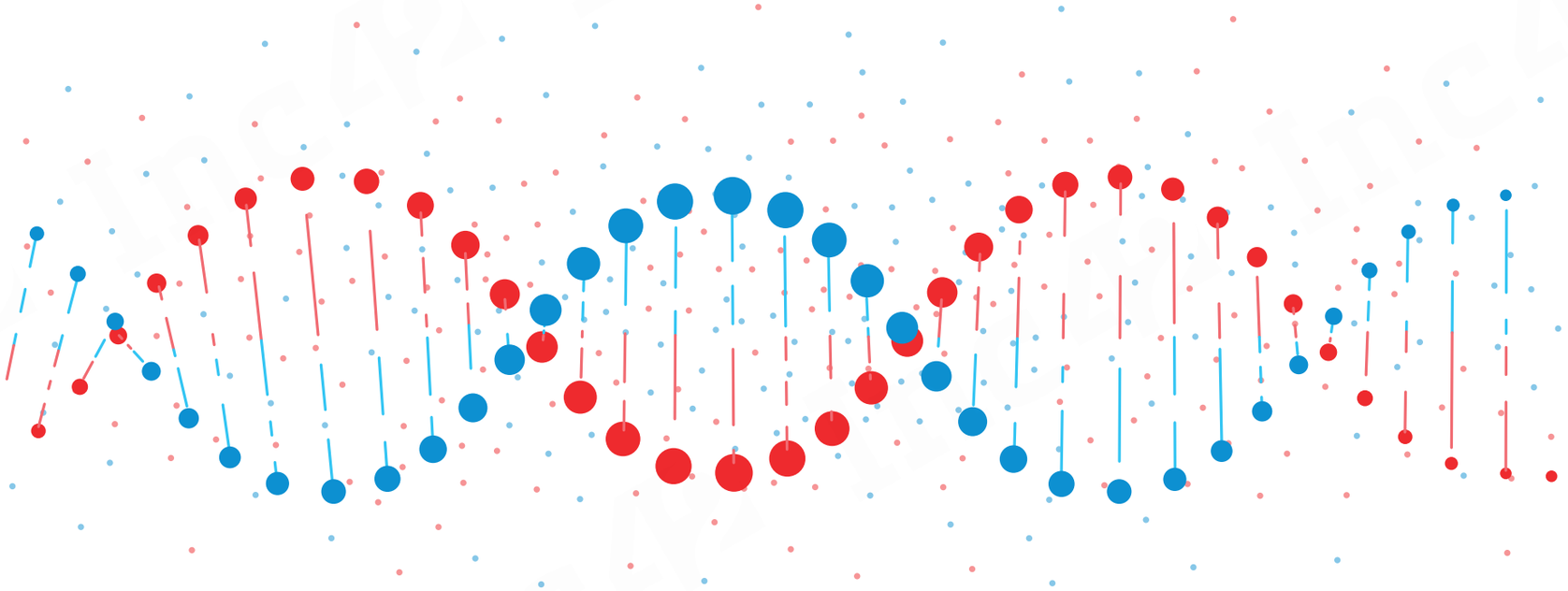
Cultural Re-Contextualisation
Mandate Cultural Re-contextualisation in Bias Evaluation

Universal Access
Design for Universal Access: Multilingual and Multimodal AI Interfaces

Community-Driven Data Strategies
Embrace Community-Driven and Context-Aware Data Strategies

Data Privacy & Worker Protection
Uphold Robust Data Privacy and Worker-Centric Protections

Responsible AI Training
Integrate Responsible AI Training Across Organisational Culture



Accountability
Ensure Accountability through Robust Quality Control Mechanisms

Digital Credential Framework
Building Trust Through a Secure, Interoperable Digital Credential Framework

Fairness Measurement
Deploy Scalable, Slice-Based Fairness Measurement

Transparent Consent
Design Transparent Consent and Non-Consensual Automation Safeguards

Public-Private Partnerships
Establish Public-Private Accountability Partnerships and Governance Frameworks

"Safety is the fundamental infrastructure allowing AI to move confidently into areas like finance, healthcare, and education, thereby forming the basis for economic growth. In India, where the digital economy is currently booming, Google is building AI systems designed to maintain user trust during the country's transition to AI."

Evan Kotsovinos

VP - Privacy, Safety & Security, Google

06

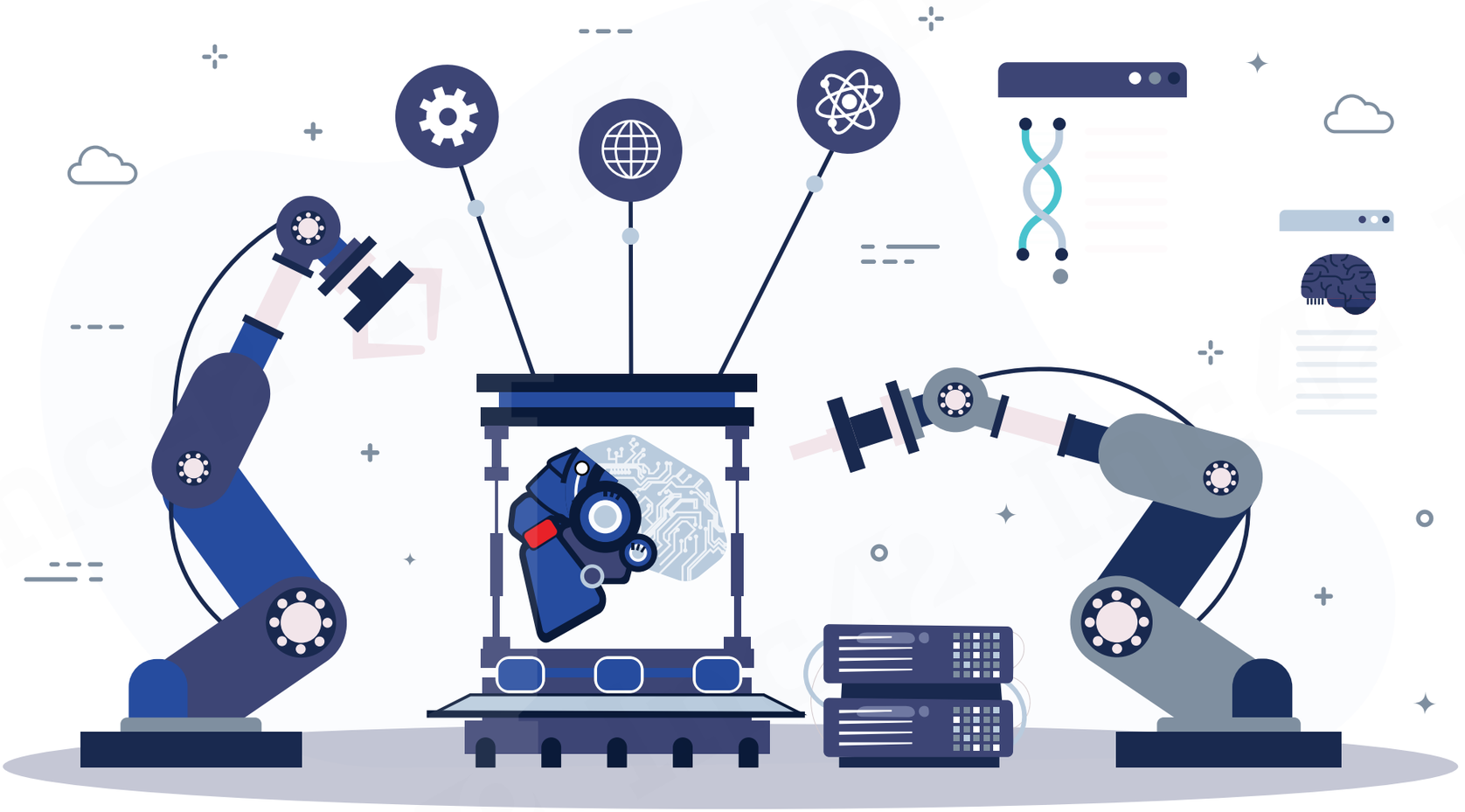
INDIA’S AI EXECUTION ERA BEGINS NOW

From Build Phase To Breakout Phase

India has moved past the “why AI” phase. Over the next two years, the center of gravity shifts from proofs of concept to full-scale systems, and this window will decide who owns production workflows, proprietary data loops, and trust-led market access in India’s AI stack.

India has reached a point where AI adoption is no longer constrained by interest, but by execution and readiness. Enterprise experimentation has become mainstream, early policy rails are reducing build friction, and platform ecosystems are compressing the time required to ship production-grade deployments.

However, the direction of advantage is shifting. As access to models and tooling becomes more widely available, technical capability alone becomes less differentiating. The next cycle will reward teams that can own workflows end-to-end, build proprietary data loops through real usage, and demonstrate trust-by-design in regulated environments.



India's Execution Strength Will Decide The Next Moats

India's near-term edge is speed-to-deployment, powered by applied engineering talent. Sustained leadership depends on closing foundational gaps in compute depth and domestic IP, while building defensibility through proprietary data loops and trust-by-design as tooling commodities.

Strengths

- India has a strong cost-to-capability advantage, enabling deep execution capacity at a lower burn rate than most mature markets
- Application-layer momentum is high, with faster iteration cycles and growing production deployments
- Policy-backed rails are reducing early build friction and widening founder participation beyond metro corridors
- A growing cohort of AI-native challengers is increasing competitive tempo and raising baseline execution standards

Weaknesses

- India's compute and data centre depth remains below mature markets, limiting reliability and resilience at scale
- Patent intensity and foundational IP creation remain limited relative to global leaders
- Hardware dependence on global supply chains continues to constrain pricing and availability cycles
- Talent supply is not keeping pace with demand in select advanced GenAI and ML roles, creating execution bottlenecks

Opportunities

- Regulated, high-ROI sectors (BFSI, healthcare, public services) remain under-built and reward workflow-native products with measurable outcomes
- Agentic automation offers an export pathway by productising service workflows and selling into global value pools
- Bharat-scale complexity can become an advantage: products hardened across languages and low-bandwidth conditions travel better globally
- Production usage can generate proprietary feedback loops, creating compounding defensibility over time

Threats / Risks

- A "wrapper economy" risk emerges if products remain thin layers without defensibility through data, trust, or distribution
- Compliance and privacy expectations can slow deployments if auditability is not engineered early
- Incumbents and global platforms can move downstream quickly once ROI is proven, raising CAC and compressing pricing power
- Advanced talent continues to face global pull factors, intensifying wage pressure and brain drain risk

The Innovation Tax Is Falling, But Winning Now Requires Defensibility

India's AI build constraints are easing across compute, language, data, talent, and capital. As baseline capability becomes easier to replicate, leadership will be determined less by building and more by compounding outcomes through repeatable deployments. The market is shifting from adoption-led to outcomes-led, where defensibility is earned in production.

What Held Back India	What's Changing Now	Anchors	What It Unlocks
Compute Economics: Global GPU pricing (~₹200+/hour) made serious experimentation capital-intensive	**Compute Becomes Operable:** Subsidised access (~₹65/hour) shifts iteration from CapEx-style risk to OpEx-friendly loops	IndiaAI compute economics (₹65/hour; expanded GPU access)	More iteration per rupee, longer runway, faster refinement cycles
Language Complexity: 22+ languages multiplied product, model and QA cycles	**Indic Rails Reduce Overhead:** Localisation becomes less repetitive and more standardised	BHASHINI; Indic model ecosystem (eg, Sarvam, BharatGen)	Multilingual capability becomes a growth lever, not a cost centre
Data Fragmentation: High-quality datasets were costly to operationalise and rebuild across pipelines	**Data Gravity:** Shared, anonymised datasets reduce rebuild and validation effort, improving training and evaluation speed	AIKosh dataset pipeline (1,200+ anonymised datasets)	Faster training and evaluation cycles; quicker sector iteration
Talent Concentration: Breakthrough teams clustered in a few metro corridors	**Talent Access Widens:** Hiring and execution capacity expands into Tier II & III cities	FutureSkills pipeline direction (towards 1 Mn+ professionals)	Broader hiring base, less dependency on a few hubs
Capital Mismatch: Deeptech timelines rarely fit conventional venture cycles, widening the "valley of death"	**Patient Capital Appears:** Long-gestation R&D is better supported alongside deployment-led capital	Patient capital direction, the central government announced (SIDBI fund-of-funds to back deeptech startups)	Stronger prototype-to-scale bridge, less pressure for premature commercialisation
Capital Signals Were Episodic: Funding was narrower and less aligned with production outcomes	**Outcome-Led Funding Increases:** More capital is oriented towards application-led, measurable deployments	~$1.8 Bn deployed into AI since 2020; rising deeptech mandates	Faster category formation, and a higher bar for defensibility

India AI Opportunity Map

As tools commoditise, advantage shifts to workflow ownership and deployment confidence. The clearest white space sits in vertical agents, Software-as-a-Service, and the infra and trust layers that make production-scale adoption possible.

Signals	Build Opportunities
Small-Share Wins Are Now Venture-Scale: India is a $126 Bn AI market by 2030; even ~0.04–0.08% share can map to a ~$50–$100 Mn outcome within one demand cycle.	**Narrow, Outcome-Led Products:** With clear ROI that can own a single workflow deeply (not "AI features") **Build For Repeat Budgets**: Measurable cost reduction, turnaround-time wins, or revenue lift
Enterprise AI Is The Bigger Value Pool: $11 Bn (2025) → $71 Bn (2030) as pilots convert into recurring rollouts	**Vertical Agentic Workflows ("job completers") In ROI-Clear Domains:** **BFSI:** Fraud, underwriting, collections, compliance ops **Healthcare:** Diagnostic support, clinical documentation, claims **Manufacturing:** Predictive maintenance, quality, supply chain ops **GovTech:** Grievance, scheme delivery ops
The Great Migration Is Underway: Chatbots → agents (execution over output) and India's services heritage is the wedge	**Software-as-a-Service Platforms:** Agents that run end-to-end tasks in back-office functions, like support ops, finance ops, sales ops, procurement ops, and then package them as repeatable software delivery
Consumer AI Monetisation Is The Open Gap: 177 Mn downloads (2024) but only ~$12 Mn consumer in-app spend. That is ~14.75 downloads per $1 of spend (≈14,750 per $1,000)	**Habit Over Novelty:** Daily-utility consumer AI with retention loops and clear "paywall moments" (subscriptions/IAP) **Build Around High-Frequency Needs:** Communication, learning, commerce, local discovery, productivity
Recurring Revenue Is The Consumer Growth Engine: App subscriptions & IAP are the fastest-growing (57% CAGR) segment as India shifts from trial to repeat paying users	**Subscription-First Consumer AI Categories:** Premium tiers for high-utility outcomes, bundles with creators/brands **Assistants:** That improve with use, such as data flywheels from everyday behaviour

India AI Opportunity Map

Signals	Build Opportunities
Bharat-Scale Complexity Becomes A Product Advantage: 886 Mn internet users and 22 languages makes India a stress-test market where trust failures surface fast	**Vernacular & Low-Friction AI:** Multilingual voice/text interfaces, translation/localisation layers, India-native evaluation sets, and “works on patchy connectivity” **Product design:** Export-ready by default once it works here
Trust Is The Gating Moat For Production: At Bharat scale, the cost of failure is higher and faster, making trust-by-design a deployment requirement, not a principles slide	**Trust Tooling As A Category:** Model monitoring, eval harnesses, audit trails, drift/bias detection, incident playbooks, privacy/data-resident design, sold as “compliance that closes deals” for enterprise procurement
Funding Is Application-Heavy → Infra Dependency risk: $1.8 Bn+ since 2020; ~86% to apps; infra/foundation pools remain small ($106 Mn infra; $130 Mn foundation)	**Infra & Enablement Whitespace:** Inference/serving stacks, deployment tooling, secure data-resident pipelines, domain fine-tuning platforms, evaluation tooling, and India-language model layers that reduce reliance on external stacks
The Dependency Reducer Is Already Forming: IndiaAI is building shared rails with ecosystem players (including Google) and public compute capacity (including 1,050 Trillium TPUs), plus DPDP-aligned cloud controls via Assured Workloads	**Build “On The Rails”:** Products that leverage public compute and compliant deployment paths for BFSI/health/public services; plus sovereign datasets/language infrastructure as defensibility
India Is Becoming A Capital-Efficient Build Base: Evidence points to lower fine-tuning cost and faster build-to-production cycles as platform maturity rises	**Export-Grade Execution Plays:** India-built products that can be rolled out globally with stronger unit economics, especially workflow agents, vernacular capability and population-scale readiness

How Founders Can Win: Workflow Ownership, Data Gravity, Trust-By-Design

As build friction falls, founders win by owning the workflow, compounding proprietary data in production, and baking trust in from day one.

The Old Way	The New Way	Founder Playbook	Strategic Focus
Thin Wrappers, General AI Shipping thin layers on global LLMs or competing on general intelligence	**Vertical Pivot** From model consumption to workflow ownership	Pick a domain and own the end-to-end job, not a feature	Measurable outcomes, integrations, repeatable deployment
Content Generation First Treating GenAI mainly as a tool for drafting, summarising, or assisting	**Software-as-a-Service** From content generation to agentic execution	Build systems that complete tasks: resolve, file, reconcile, procure	Task automation with controls, not just “assist”
Tech Complexity = Moat Assuming hard engineering alone will create durable defensibility	**Execution Velocity** Speed as the primary moat	As build cycles compress, advantage shifts to iteration speed and shipping cadence	Production learning loops before categories harden
Dollar Premium, High Costs Building on global infra pricing that makes iteration structurally expensive	**The Arbitrage Advantage** Sovereign cost curve, global yield	Build on India’s economics (compute, talent & rails) and sell into global value pools	“Build for ₹, sell for $” unit economics by design
Collateral “Responsible AI” Checklist Treating trust, governance, and compliance as late stage overhead	**Trust-By-Design** Compliance as market access	Embed auditability, safety, and DPDP-aligned controls from day one, especially in regulated sectors	Trust becomes a sales feature, not an afterthought
Open Datasets, Public Benchmarks Competing on accessible data and generic evaluation standards	**Data Gravity** The proprietary flywheel	Defensibility shifts from the model to the unique, messy, domain data created in production	Feedback loops that compound performance over time
Endless PoCs Stalling in pilots without production readiness, ROI clarity, or scale pathways	**Industrialisation** Escaping “PoC purgatory”	Design for production early: ROI metrics, monitoring, governance, incident readiness	Pilot-to-production discipline built into the deployment plan

What It Takes To Convert India's AI Moment Into Market Leadership

India's AI build constraints are easing across compute, language, data, talent, and capital. As baseline capability becomes easier to replicate, leadership will be determined less by building and more by compounding outcomes through repeatable deployments. The market is shifting from adoption-led to outcomes-led, where defensibility is earned in production.

Founders

Don't Build Models, Build Businesses: Pick a domain with hard ROI, design for production-grade deployment early, and prioritise systems that complete jobs end-to-end (not just assist)

Turn Usage Into Proprietary Advantage: Instrument workflows so production generates clean, domain-specific feedback data that improves performance and compounds over time

Build Trust-By-Design: Implement DPDP-aligned privacy controls, traceable audit logs, India-relevant bias/robustness testing, and clear human-escalation paths for high-stakes decisions

Investors

Back Production Adoption, Not PoC: Prioritise evidence of deployment readiness, measurable customer outcomes, and repeatable workflow value over demo quality or benchmark lifts

Diligence Data Gravity And Trust Readiness: Evaluate proprietary feedback loops, data residency posture, and auditability as core underwriting criteria, especially in regulated sectors

Allocate For Durability, Not Just Velocity: Support longer build cycles where defensibility depends on workflow depth, data accumulation, and compliance maturity, rather than forcing premature scaling narratives

Policy

Keep Compute Predictable, Affordable And Reliable: Treat compute as utility infrastructure with improving uptime, capacity and geographic distribution as more startups move from pilots to production

Shorten The Path From Sandbox To Scale: Use sector sandboxes, outcome-based evaluation playbooks, and faster pathways for compliant deployment in BFSI, healthcare and public services

Strengthen Shared Datasets And Talent Corridors: Expand high-quality public datasets, fund applied AI labs, and widen Tier II & III capability to ease execution bottlenecks

Platforms & Ecosystem Enablers

Strip Friction Out Of Going Live: Offer reusable deployment primitives, integration accelerators, monitoring/evaluation tooling, and security baselines that shorten implementation cycles

Standardise Trust Tooling: Provide shared approaches to testing, red-teaming, monitoring and audit readiness to reduce duplicated effort and raise baseline reliability

Build Export Rails For India-Built Workflows: Support distribution partnerships, cross-border compliance playbooks and market-entry support so India-hardened products can access global value pools

2026–2027 Will Set India's AI Category Leaders

Build barriers are easing across compute, data, language and capital. Advantage shifts to teams that convert experimentation into production outcomes and defensibility.

2025–2027

PMF & pilots → production workflows (distribution still open)

2028–2029

Category consolidation (higher CAC, weaker pricing power)

2030+: incumbency phase

Data & trust compound for winners

What Needs To Move In Sync

Founders

Build workflow-native products that complete jobs end to end; instrument usage into proprietary data loops; design trust-by-default for regulated deployment.

Investors

Back production adoption and repeatable outcomes, not just demos; diligence data gravity and auditability early; underwrite durability where defensibility compounds over time.

Policy

Keep compute and data rails predictable, affordable and reliable; shorten sandbox-to-scale pathways in regulated sectors; expand shared datasets and Tier II & III capability.

Platforms & Ecosystem Enablers

Reduce go-live friction with reusable deployment primitives; standardise trust tooling (testing, monitoring, audit readiness); strengthen export readiness for India-built workflows.

Over the next few years, India's AI winners will be the teams that turn momentum into habit — making AI indispensable inside real workflows for real users. This cycle will be defined less by who builds fastest, and more by what sticks and stays trusted at India scale.

Methodology And Definitions

Since 2015, Inc42 has served as a definitive source for tracking Indian startups that are transforming industries and shaping the country's digital economy.

Key Definitions

- **AI Natives:** Indian startups where AI is core to the product from day one, shaping the proposition, delivery, and unit economics
- **AI Adopters:** Established Indian tech startups that integrated GenAI into existing offerings after founding, rather than being built with GenAI at the core
- **Funding Stages**
  - **Seed Stage:** Angel / Seed rounds
  - **Growth Stage:** Series A / Series B
  - **Late Stage:** Series C and above
- **Unicorn:** Any digital/tech company valued at $1 Bn or above, or that has touched this valuation at least once
- **Market Size Convention:** Unless specified otherwise, market size refers to the Total Addressable Market (TAM), estimated using a blend of top-down and bottom-up methods

Data Notes: Our database is regularly enriched As a result, minor variations in funding-related data versus previously released Inc42 reports may occur

Market Opportunity Estimation

- **Enterprise AI:** The Enterprise AI opportunity in India is estimated by assessing what share of corporate IT expenditure (including hardware) is AI-relevant, and what portion of that is expected to shift towards production-grade AI products and services over time
  - **Approach**
    - **Identify AI-Relevant IT Spend:** Estimated using the proportion of total IT expenditure across categories where AI integration is applicable and economically meaningful
    - **Account for production deployment:** Within AI-relevant segments, we estimated the share of budgets moving from experimentation to production-level AI deployments
  - **Estimation Function:** Enterprise AI Market Opportunity = (Total Indian IT Spend) × (% AI-Relevant)
    - **Total Indian IT Spend** is sourced from secondary research published by widely recognised industry organisations
    - **% AI-Relevant** reflects both (a) the theoretical applicability of AI across IT categories and (b) observed rates of production deployment in those categories
  - **Base Year:** 2025
  - **Projection Period:** five years

This approach is designed to capture both the addressable budget pool and the portion realistically expected to shift towards AI products and services

Methodology And Definitions

Consumer AI: The Consumer AI opportunity in India is estimated by quantifying the share of consumer technology spend attributable to AI-enabled products and services across three categories

- **Components**
  - **Consumer Electronics:** The AI-linked share of consumer electronics spend on devices where AI features materially drive value (eg, smartphones with embedded AI capabilities, wearables, smart TVs) This is informed by secondary research on category mix and feature adoption
  - **In-App Purchases & Subscriptions:** We assessed spending on digital subscriptions and services (eg, productivity, wellness, streaming), and estimated the AI-relevant share where personalisation, recommendation systems, or GenAI features form a meaningful part of the proposition
  - **Smart Home:** We considered spend on smart home devices (eg, voice assistants, connected appliances, security systems), estimating the AI-linked portion based on reliance on AI for automation, natural language interaction, or predictive functionality
- **Estimation Function: Consumer AI Market Opportunity = (Total Consumer Tech Spend) × (% AI-Relevant)**
  - **Total Consumer Tech Spend** is derived from secondary research published by recognised industry sources
  - **% AI-Relevant** reflects both theoretical applicability and observed adoption of AI-enabled products and services within each category
- **Base Year:** 2025
- **Projection** Period: Five years

This framework is intended to capture both the broad spend pool and the portion credibly attributable toAI-driven value in the Indian market

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